

Phil 350 Plato: The Dawn of Thought

Numbered Transcript

PHIL 350 • Dr. James Orr

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Lecture 1: Plato's World

At a glance — Dr. James Orr opens the six-part series on Plato and his legacy, taking Whitehead's line that European philosophy is 'footnotes to Plato' as a starting provocation. He sets Plato's intellectual, cultural, and political hinterland — the Greek world, the pre-Socratics, and the shadow of Socrates — before turning to the dialogues themselves.

- 1.1** Welcome, everyone, to this, the first lecture in a series titled "The Dawn of Thought." The Dawn of Thought: Plato and His Legacy. You may think that that phrase, "the dawn of thought," is a bit grand. Did thought begin? And could it begin with just one man? Well, let me explain a little bit why I think that phrase is appropriate for this series. There was a great German philosopher called Karl Jaspers. He coined this phrase about a hundred years ago called "The Axial Age." And he noted that in the period from roughly the 8th century BC through to the third century BC, in China, in Iran, in Palestine, and in Greece, there emerged almost simultaneously an extraordinary appetite for understanding fundamental reality and for reflecting in incredibly sophisticated ways about reality.
- 1.2** So in China, we have the figure of Confucius, emerging—Laozi, Mozi. In India, we have the great quickening of the Vedic tradition from the ritualistic into the philosophical with the Upanishads, the Bhagavad Gita. In Iran, the birth of Zoroastrianism. Very complex theories about the cosmos and the place of human beings within the cosmos. In Palestine, the great prophetic tradition, from Elijah through to Jeremiah to Isaiah, emerges—especially intensifying in the 6th centuries, 5th centuries BC.
- 1.3** And of course, finally in Greece, in Europe, the only European region for all of those civilizations. In Greece, we see the emergence in the 6th and 5th centuries of an extraordinary range of avenues of human inquiry. In this short, brilliant golden age centered around Athens, we see the birth of democracy, albeit not in a form we may be used to today. We see the birth of drama. No one had thought to do theater before—the birth of drama, the birth of tragedy in the 490s, 480s, 470s. And the birth of history, with the figure of Herodotus and Thucydides. The birth of anthropology in Herodotus—Herodotus is obsessively interested, not just in history, but in people, different customs and practices and so on. Thucydides is not just a historian, he's also an economist.
- 1.4** We see with the great figure of Aristotle in the 4th century, the birth of psychology. No one had thought to think about "What is the mind, what makes us tick psychologically?". We see the birth of botany, of biology, of physics, of meteorology, all in one place, one tiny city-state, numbering 10-15, maybe 20 thousand citizens at most, supported by an enormous infrastructure of human slavery. And this is what largely permitted these brilliant minds to take "leisure ". The Greek word for leisure is "skhole". To be a scholar is to be somebody who has the leisure to explore these questions. So we have this extraordinary fizz in the development of humanity, this

extraordinary ferment, this kind of explosive intellectual phase in the history of humanity in that short period intensifying in Greece.

- 1.5 So why Plato? Why are we going to be spending the next six lectures focusing on this one man? We're going to be doing it because no other single figure, or so I'm going to argue, distills as powerfully all of the different ideas that are emerging in that half millennium period, all across those different regions. Nobody else applies the same power of scrutiny, the same sophistication to these different questions. One of your great thinkers, Ralph Waldo Emerson, once said, "Plato is philosophy, and philosophy is Plato." That 's not an exaggeration.
- 1.6 One of my countrymen, Alfred North Whitehead, who migrated to the United States, spent a lot of his time in Harvard, once wrote that, "The safest general characterization of European philosophy is that it consists in a series of footnotes to Plato." Footnotes to Plato. Two and a half thousand years of human thought—arguably the best human thought; certainly in the West, but also of incalculable influence elsewhere, too—in this one figure. Many might think that's a bit of an exaggeration. And Whitehead was careful. He said, "I don't mean that everyone just took on Plato's systems and ideas, but that if you really went through a history of Western philosophy, you see his fingerprints everywhere." "You'll see his fingerprints everywhere." Sometimes you'll see them most clearly in the philosophers who can't stand him. And we often see that in the development of human thought. Influence can be negative as well as positive.
- 1.7 Nietzsche couldn't stand Plato—for reasons we'll come on to in lecture five—and so he couldn't stop writing about him. So we're all, as it were, living in Plato's shadow. And so what I hope to do in the next six lectures is not just to introduce you to Plato, but to give you a compressed introduction to philosophy: to all of philosophy. And I hope in the next six hours, six lectures, we're not actually going to leave or omit, leave out any significant aspect in a three-year standard philosophy program at an Ivy League university—or even better, Oxford or Cambridge.
- 1.8 We'll be looking at all of these different aspects. We'll be looking at the nature of fundamental reality. That sounds a little bit strange. I'll hope to demystify that. Some of you here may not even quite know what the word "philosophy" is supposed to mean. Walking through an airport yesterday and seeing the philosophy section, a lot of the books there would be what you might call "self-help"—that is to say, the idea there is that philosophy is "the code that you live by, " maybe, "the code that you live by." I don 't want to belittle that way of thinking about philosophy, and I hope that by the end of these lectures you will actually have a very good understanding of what it might mean to select a code and to understand your place in the world. But that's not where we're going to begin. We're not going to be beginning with just the "self." We're going to be zooming in. We're going to be—first of all, we're going to start from the biggest, the widest lens we can, and then we're going to zoom right into the place of human beings in the world and what human flourishing and human happiness might consist in.

- 1.9** So what is philosophy? It's exploring fundamental reality. Now, what is fundamental reality? What could we even mean by that phrase? Well, it could be that it's just "stuff." That 's the dominant orthodoxy today. It's just "matter." And because everything is matter, nothing matters. Because you're just matter, you don't matter. This philosophy, this disposition, this way of thinking, born out of the Scientific Revolution in the Enlightenment Period—shall we say roughly 1650 to 1800? Well, let's be more precise: 1596, the birth of Descartes, to 1804, the death of Immanuel Kant. The great Age of Enlightenment, so called the "birth of rationality," "the birth of science," as the textbooks like to convince us. What a strange, self-congratulatory way to talk about a period. "Enlightenment." What comes before 1596, if 1596 marks the beginning of the Enlightenment? "Darkness," the Dark Ages. What I want to suggest is actually: the Enlightenment has brought with us, has brought in its wake, not so much, not only illumination, but also gloom—gloom about our place in the world and what the world is.
- 1.10** It's brought with it, in the words of the great German sociologist Max Weber, "disenchantment,"—disenchantment, we feel disenchanted. "Entzauberung" was his phrase, his word.
- 1.11** So we have this strange paradox: the more we come to understand about the world scientifically, the more tempting it becomes to identify fundamental reality as just "what science tells us there is." The more disenchanted, and the less at ease, we become in the world that we've come to understand so much better. This is the great paradox.
- 1.12** Now, why is that? Well, the sheer success of the natural sciences has led philosophers to believe that the sciences must be onto something, or at least that what science explores, and itemizes, and discovers, and tells us so many extraordinary things about, and achieves such practical success with must—in the end—be what all of reality is about. Sometimes it's called "nothing buttery". Oh, yes. You may think you're conscious, you may think that morality is true. And out there, there is a moral universe beyond the physical universe. You may think that listening to Beethoven's fourth piano Concerto is somehow tasting the divine, but all of that is "nothing but" the natural sciences. Nothing but, everything, all of that can be explained simply in terms of the physiology of our physiology, of our neurons in the brain. Everything can be understood in reductive Darwinian terms.
- 1.13** Plato inherits just this way of thinking about the world. And one of the things, one of the movements he is trying to challenge, is exactly this attempt to reduce everything down to "stuff." So in the 5th century BC, we see the emergence in Ionia—which is that part of, now is the western coast of Turkey, in effect; but then was a Greek-dominated part of the world—we see the emergence of the first scientists, you might say. Somebody like Thales, who we don't have anything, we don't have extensive works of his, we've just got to work with fragments. But it seems as if Thales was committed to

the idea that all of reality was made of water. It all came down to water. Anaximenes thought, oh, well, it's all air. Everything is air. Heraclitus says everything was fire, fire and flux and change. And that got married to another tradition, the atomist tradition of Empedocles and Democritus, saying, "yes, well, whatever these ultimate units are, they're just particular little atoms, and all of reality is made up of these little atoms."

- 1.14 That, if you like, is something very close to the kind of dominant scientific and philosophical orthodoxies with us today. Obviously, the science is a lot more complex, the theorizing is a lot more sophisticated, but that is ultimately the materialistic worldview that reduces everything down to matter, that Plato begins to turn against as he comes of age.
- 1.15 There's another stream of thinking that he's reacting against—which also has its descendant stalking the corridors of the academy and offices, and walking the streets today. And that is what we might call just "Relativism." Relativism. Roughly speaking, the idea that truth, that there is no capital "T" truth, truth is relative to the subject, truth is relative to the culture, to the society. Nothing—there can be no hierarchy of truths, there can be no objective truths. This is the great claim of the so-called "postmodernists," the "post-structuralists": that truth, and meaning, and value, are plastic—are in a state of total, complete flux—can never be pinned down. Some of the figures that Plato would have heard lecturing in Athens in the Agora—no doubt he would have met many of them—were known by the collective term of "Sophists." Sophists from the Greek word "sophos," meaning wise and "sophisticos, sophistices," the wise person.
- 1.16 And in fact, we've got a play, a comedy from Aristophanes that identifies Plato's great teacher, Socrates, as a Sophist. And Sophists were wandering lecturers who took money to train the great and the good, or the children of the great and the good, in the art of rhetoric, of speech-making. This is a time when democracy has just emerged in around about 500 BC.
- 1.17 So this, the first half of the 5th century, democracy is emerging in this radical form. Everything centered on an "ecclesia," an assembly of 10,000, a "boule," a kind of inner cabinet of 500, and a presidency that rotated daily. And winning over that crowd meant you needed to be good at rhetoric—you needed to be good at winning over a crowd by any means necessary. And the Sophists were brilliant at training aspiring, ambitious politicians to win over the crowds, to develop and to take up a perspective that was going to work for them to achieve their goals. Not to track truth—as Plato began to complain and Socrates began to see—but to secure power, to secure self-interest. And so, for the Sophist, truth was as malleable and as flexible and as plastic as for Derrida and for Foucault and for Lyotard—the great Francophone triumvirate of postmodernism.
- 1.18 So one of the reasons it makes sense to be spending so much time on Plato is that he counters these two great traditions that are with us still. The tradition of a "reductive

naturalism"—kind of science worship, science as the end all and be all, the ultimate referee, the ultimate arbiter of what's real—on the one hand. And on the other hand, a tradition that says "nothing's really real, except my own thinking makes it so."

- 1.19** Plato's great influence, of course, was Socrates. Born in 470, put on trial and executed in 399 BC. The great shock of Plato's life. And the moment at the end of this extraordinary century, when Athens had been the place where all of these different avenues of human achievement, that I mentioned earlier, arose; and yet a place that was also a home for civil war, for genocide, slavery, for extraordinary genuine tragedy and human suffering and human evil. And Plato is wrestling with all of this, and he sees in the figure of Socrates something like a saint. Now, of course, we don't know a great deal more about Socrates than we find in Plato's Dialogues. We have an account of him by an Athenian general, not a terribly bright or learned man, Xenophon. And we have this great caricature of him by Aristophanes in that comedy I mentioned earlier.
- 1.20** Nevertheless, we can form an interesting view of him, even though he never wrote a word. Extraordinary to think that—one of the most influential philosophers in history never wrote a word, or at least never wrote a word that has come down to us. Jesus of Nazareth never wrote a word, but exercised incalculable, incalculable influence. Homer didn't write a word—it's simply memory and oral tradition. Extraordinary thing to think about. And we'll see when we come on to discuss Plato's Dialogues that there's a great suspicion about the written word.
- 1.21** What characterizes Socrates, as his personality emerges for us in the early Dialogues of Plato, is a restless seeking after truth. He is obsessed with finding the right answer. And that put him at odds with, and made him a great threat to, the sophistic tradition ; because he wasn't interested in power, he wasn't interested in training the great and the good to learn how to win over a political assembly. He was simply interested in how we get to understand the world and how we can say that we know something and we can defend it.
- 1.22** If you're starting with Plato, I'd recommend starting with the Apology—Plato's Apology. It's Plato's Apology in that Plato wrote it, but there are good grounds for thinking that it represents something very close to the speech that Socrates made, in his own defense, at his trial in 399 BC.
- 1.23** He's on trial for two charges. Charge number one: he is introducing new gods—deeply destabilizing. He's introducing new gods into the city-state. Remember, this is a city-state; this is a culture, like most ancient cultures, that is tied to, oriented towards, stabilized, and ordered by civic religion. This is not really a kind of philosophical religion. It's a religion of cults and common worship that stitches a society and a community together. The second charge: corrupting the youth. Corrupting the youth. Now, it's not always, not quite clear how those charges were understood by the prosecution, but we get a good sense of why Socrates was creating this kind of criticism—was leaving himself open to these sorts of charges—as we read the Apology.

- 1.24 Here's a quick quote. Chaerephon asked the Delphic Oracle, the Oracle of Delphi, about 2 hours drive northwest of Athens, the "center of the world," the Greeks called it the "omphalos tou kósmou", the "belly button of the Cosmos", and it was allegedly the source of all wisdom, but it gave its pronouncements in a famously enigmatic way.
- 1.25 So Socrates says, "Chaerephon went to ask the Delphic Oracle if 'anyone was wiser than I?' and the Oracle said, 'no'. Knowing my ignorance, I wondered what the Oracle could mean, and I thought of a plan to test the reply. I went to a man with a reputation for wisdom, a statesman, a politician, so wise, hoping to be able to say, 'you said I was the wisest, but this statesman is wiser.' But I found, in fact, that the politician was not in fact wise, and I was just that little bit wiser in that at least I knew my ignorance. I tried others with the same result and it angered them, "—you can feel the rage is coming through in the responses that he generates—"and that made me sorry and afraid. But I had to take the Oracle seriously. I couldn't just reject the Oracle. So I discovered quite quickly that the people with the biggest reputations were the worst. Poets were so far from being able to explain their own poems that I could only conclude that they didn't write from knowledge, but in a divine trance, like prophets.
- 1.26 Yet because of their poetry, they thought themselves wise in other matters too. So I decided that I had the same advantage over them as over the politicians. Lastly, I went to the craftsmen. Now, they certainly had valuable knowledge that I lacked, and in this respect, they were wiser, but they made the same mistake as the poets, because they were good at their craft, they thought they understood the highest matters too. So I decided that I was just better off as I was without their knowledge, but also without their kind of ignorance. The Oracle was right."
- 1.27 Socrates goes on to suggest at the end of the Apology that he shouldn't be put to death—was given the option of exile or death. He says, "Neither." "Or what do you think is appropriate, Socrates?" "I think you should put me up at public expense and allow me to dine off the state for the rest of my life. You should give me free dinners, the city of Athens should give me free dinners in the town hall, the Prytaneis, for the rest of my life, because of the wisdom I am bringing, the illumination I am bringing, in suggesting that none of these people know as much as they think they do."
- 1.28 We see in that speech the beginnings of philosophy. Why? Because Socrates is asking very, very general questions. "What is the nature of knowledge?" "How can we get under the skin of any subject and ask, 'But why? What is this? Ultimately, why?'" You go to a university today, you will see in the philosophy department philosophies of almost everything. It's really the only subject that is a meta -subject. There's a philosophy of religion, there's the philosophy of language, there's the philosophy of beauty, esthetics, the philosophy of mathematics, philosophy of literature. How is that possible? Well, it's possible because of this original Socratic insight that you can ask of everything, "yes, but what is it really?" The poets can't tell us, the craftsmen can't tell us, the statesman can't tell us—they've got their own disciplines. And yet, because of

the success they acquire, and within their own disciplines, they think they can step out of those disciplines and hold forth on questions they don't actually know anything about.

- 1.29** Think of Hollywood celebrities being asked about inconceivably complex policy questions about, say, the environment, or war, or finance, or economics and taxation. Or think about the contemporary Cult of Scientism. This idea that scientists are the great high priests of our age—a Richard Dawkins or a Neil deGrasse Tyson, or a Lawrence Krauss. Well, what are they? They're brilliant biologists and cosmologists and so on. But their success in those extremely refined, sophisticated corners of the natural sciences somehow gives them a passport to holding forth on all kinds of different questions about human flourishing and about our future and so on and so forth. So this tendency, this problem that Socrates diagnoses, is with us still today.
- 1.30** What are we going to be looking at in this series? A quick overview. In this lecture, we're really looking at Plato's world, his intellectual world, the cultural world, his place in the development of human thought in the Axial Age. In the next lecture, we're going to be looking at the secret weapon that Socrates gives him—the technique that allows philosophy to get off the ground in such a way that we've not really been able to shake it off since—and that is "dialectic," dialogue, conversation, the give and take between people who are collaborators in a common inquiry after truth. That'll be the next lecture.
- 1.31** In lecture three, we're going to be looking at the two great themes of Plato's work and his two greatest achievements: his account of what the world is—what ultimate reality is, whether it is just matter, or whether there's something more than matter—and how we can go about having any, getting any kind, of access to that. The problem of being, or "ontology," as the philosophers like to say, and the problem of knowledge or "epistemology," to give it its technical term—being and knowing. We may think we know what being is, what nature is, what supernature is or is not, but we have to have some kind of account of how we got there. So to understand "being," we need to understand "knowing." And from those, those are the two engines of Plato's thought, and they remain the two engines of philosophy as such, as it's practiced today in all philosophy departments. Sometimes called "M and E": Metaphysics, being, the study of being, the study of ultimate being and "E": Epistemology, theory of knowledge, how we come to perceive the world and how we come to know the world.
- 1.32** So that's lecture three, and then we're going to move on in lecture four, to look at Plato on politics, the philosophy of politics, political philosophy. And part of Plato's genius is that he shows us how understanding being, understanding knowledge, also involves coming to understand "the good." And that only once we can come to understand the good, can we even begin to ask, "How should we order ourselves as a person? How should we order our souls? What is a soul? And how can we possibly organize a community of souls? How do we structure it?" And we'll see in that lecture that Plato

irritates everyone. He irritates the right because he's got some very radical left proposals about the role of the state in particular. And he would infuriate the left, certainly, because of his commitment to hierarchy within a community, his profound suspicion of democracy as the right tool to deliver justice and harmony and social order. So we're going to have fun in that lecture.

1.33 And the fifth lecture, we're going to be looking at Plato's Afterlives. This is going to be a challenging lecture because we're going to be looking at, really in lecture five and lecture six, you can think of that final third as looking at the theme of "From Plato to NATO, " and maybe also mischievously, given the context, from "Plato to Peterson." And I'll be saying a little bit about why I've been trying to persuade Dr. Peterson to be more Platonic. And we'll have a look at, right at the end about, look at a comparison of Jung and Plato amongst others.

1.34 But anyway, in that lecture five—so the first half of that final third of the series—we'll be really looking at the impact of Plato and the Platonic schools all the way through the Hellenistic age, up through into the early years of Christianity. That extraordinary fusion of the Hebraic and the Hellenic in Philo of Alexandria, and the great impact that that fusion has on East and West. We'll be looking at Augustine, we'll be looking at in the 4th and 5th centuries; we'll be looking at Boethius in the 5th and 6th centuries. We'll be looking at Anselm and Aquinas in the 12th and 13th centuries. And we'll be looking at Plato's rebirth in Florence in the Renaissance, in the 1480s, with the great figures of Marsilio Ficino and Pico della Mirandola.

1.35 And then in the final lecture, we'll be looking at the theme of Plato today, Plato today, and how his ideas persist in every area of philosophy; including in the modern university, even in my own university, which, the University of Cambridge, which is a university that has been historically, at least in the last 100, 150 years, extremely skeptical of Plato's impact. But, as somebody said, of metaphysics itself, one could say of Plato that he "always buries his undertakers." He always buries his undertakers. He's had many great critics over the last two and a half thousand years, but he's outlived all of them.

1.36 So to come in to land today, we've looked at Plato's world. We've looked a little bit at the question of "Why Plato?" Why are we thinking about this figure? What we haven't looked at is the problem of "Which Plato?" There are many different Platos, and this is a challenge that we're going to be focusing on in particular in the next lecture. The challenge is that, just as Socrates never wrote a word, Plato never wrote a word either. What do I mean by that? Well, Plato wrote dialogues, not treatises, not long speeches or long lectures. He gave lectures—we don't have any of them. All he wrote were dialogues. But he's never in any of the Dialogues. Well, in one Dialogue, one of the characters says that he's present—that's in the Apology—yeah, Plato's there. And in one other Dialogue, the Phaedo, which describes the scene immediately after the trial of Socrates, with Socrates taking the hemlock—amazing meditation—as he's taking the

hemlock and slowly dying and comforting his friends through philosophy, one of the characters says, "Plato's not here." Plato's not here. But there is no character Plato in any of the 35 Dialogues, who says anything.

- 1.37** So he never wrote a word in his own name. In all of those Dialogues, Plato is nowhere and Plato is everywhere. In another of them, the *Phaedrus*—one of the most beautiful works of literature in the West ever written—we're told that Socrates and his companion, as they leave the city and they go and take cover in the midday sun under a tree, "ypó tó plátanos," underneath the Plato tree. The *Platonos*, the Plato tree, was a big sort of plane tree, a plane tree that were common in the groves around Athens. It's a little joke: Plato's not in the Dialogue, but the whole dialogue happens under his artistry.
- 1.38** One of the few ancient biographies we have of Plato describes him as growing up as a teenager wanting to be the next Sophocles, the next Euripides, the next Aeschylus—a tragedian. He wanted to write tragedies that would win the first prize at the annual Festival of the Dionysia. And the day he met Socrates, he abandoned that ambition. And Diogenes Laërtius tells us that he went back that evening and burnt all of his drafts, burnt all of his tragedies, because he had met the man that he was going to devote the rest of his life to. Now, we don't know how fanciful that is—it's very difficult to work out how accurate that biography is—there's good reason for thinking that a lot of it is quite accurate. But it tells us a deep truth about Plato. It tells us that there was something—it was very plausible to suggest that anecdote about a figure like that, because he is one of the greatest writers that the West has ever produced.
- 1.39** His Greek is superb. It's particularly the middle Dialogues, the *Phaedrus*, and the *Phaedo*, and the *Republic*, and the *Symposium*—these are written in a quite extraordinary way. The extraordinary fluency and attention to detail and literary skill, development of character, dramatic energy and pathos. It's very strange to read philosophy that is, in a way, that you are moved by it. You are moved by what's happening—you're moved by the give and take.
- 1.40** There's a moment at the end of one of the Dialogues, the *Symposium*: a big drinking party which ends with all of them, effectively, passed out from too much alcohol. And the sun is coming up. And there's one, apart from Socrates, there's one person just still conscious, and Socrates as clear as a bell, completely sober, gently trying to persuade this man that one and the same person could write tragedy and comedy—unthinkable in Athens. Two different competitions: you either became a tragedian or you became a satirist. Socrates says, "no, one and the same person can do both." And in the figure of Plato, we have high comedy and extraordinary pathos, poignancy and tragedy. And part of what Plato later argues is that poets, dramatists, tragedians, comedians, satirists, can be a real problem within the state, and that poetry and drama and art must be anchored to clear thinking—to clear reasoning. And Plato exemplifies that, Plato

embodies that and, as it were, performs that truth in his literary artistry and in his power.

- 1.41** So anyway, back to the original thought, the original question. "Which Plato?" You can start to see how hard that question is. Plato is nowhere and Plato is everywhere. Which character—is he Socrates? Socrates is in almost all of the Dialogues, except one. Most of the time he wins, sometimes he loses. In one of the Dialogues, the *Parmenides*, probably written towards the end of Plato's life, Plato's biggest theory or his biggest idea, the "Theory of Ideas,"—we'll talk about that in lecture three—is given a level of scrutiny, that means by the end of the Dialogue, you think, "why did Plato take that theory seriously at all?" Socrates is defeated—Socrates loses, defending the position that Plato is today still most associated with. Now, I want to suggest that that capacity for self-criticism is also part of Plato's genius. He was willing to expose his own ideas to the cold light of the most sophisticated criticism he could find. The great figure of *Parmenides*, one of the great Sophists, defeats Socrates, trying to defend Plato's greatest scheme, greatest idea.
- 1.42** There's a lesson in that. As you all embark on the journey of philosophy, as you all embark on thinking about the nature of reality—what it is to come to know the real, to see it, to perceive it, to understand it, and to live your own life within it, that thought, "You might be wrong." I might be wrong, and I'm not going to know if I'm wrong if I don't continually expose the beliefs that I think are right to criticism and to scrutiny.
- 1.43** One of Dr. Peterson's great achievements, of course, in contemporary culture has been to argue insistently, relentlessly, for the importance of freedom of conscience and freedom of speech. Because if we don't have that, as Plato understood and as Socrates understood, we 'll never get to the truth, we'll never get to what 's real, because the chances are: we might be wrong. It's possible even if you think you're not, you might be wrong. But we're never going to know if we're wrong if we haven't exposed our beliefs to scrutiny and if we're not willing to engage in self-criticism. And also it's very likely that some of our beliefs are right and some of them are wrong, and we're never going to know which ones are right and which ones are wrong if we, again, haven't put that through the kind of Socratic dialectic and scrutiny that we're going to be talking about in the next lecture.
- 1.44** And finally, and this is a phrase from the great John Stuart Mill in his second chapter of "On Liberty," (1859), "He who knows only his own side, knows little of that." He who knows only his own side, knows little of that.
- 1.45** As we'll see, the genius of the dialogue form that Plato chooses as the vehicle for his philosophy is that it gives us confidence as we follow Socrates. It gives us confidence that he is able to sift through and defend his positions, that he understands them because he's willing to expose them to the sharpest criticism. Every single character advances a different perspective. Nobody, therefore, can know only their own side.

Once you know all of the sides, you understand your own. It's the only way you're going to understand your own side.

- 1.46** Well, that concludes the first lecture. And since we've been talking about dialogue and the importance of dialogue in philosophy, I think it's time we open things up for dialogue, for questions, for thoughts, reflections. Gentleman, over there:
- 1.47** So since Sophists were huge advocates for relativism, would Sophists have ever come to be without Greece first being in a postmodern age? And if not then, if not then would our association of truth with Sophists right now be different, which, by extension, affects how we view truth in today's age?
- 1.48** Thank you. So the question there is: do we see in the contemporary world, across the contemporary landscape, of intellectuals, sophistic types, sophistic types of reasoning, patterns of reasoning, and does that destabilize a sense that there's a capital "T", Truth? Is that the question? "Yes. " Yeah. Well, I think that's right. And one of the interesting, just to flesh that out a little bit, I'd say that it's good for us all to think about philosophy as distinct from, say, something like the natural sciences.
- 1.49** So the natural sciences make progress. It's a body of knowledge that is growing and sometimes shrinking as we ditch certain parts of it, and we can make progress. We can say that scientifically, we know far more about the world than we do, than we did, two and a half thousand years ago. One of the most wonderful and frustrating features of philosophy is that it's not like that. It's frustrating to be engaged in something that you can't make progress in. You can't just say, "Right, we've settled that argument, God does exist," or, "we've settled this argument, this is what knowledge is." Can't do that. Philosophy doesn't traffic in scientific truths or mathematical truths or proofs. There are no proofs in philosophy. I think it was Cicero, and Descartes as well, said something similar. "There is no idea in the whole history of human thought that isn't so crazy that some philosopher somewhere hasn't been willing to defend it."
- 1.50** So back to your question. Relativism is with us today, and sophistry is with us today, and the sophistic figures are with us today—just as they were in 5th century Athens—because there's no way in the end to disprove them. You say to the relativist, "relativism is false," "but that's just your opinion," says the relativist, or "that's true relative to you, but not relative to me," and so on. You go down a rabbit hole very quickly. But in the end, there'll come a point where you're having a discussion or a dialogue with somebody, and they will simply not accept your point of view, no matter how many powerful arguments you advance. And there'll come a point where you simply need to walk away—and just walk away. There's no proof you can guide them through.
- 1.51** And a lot of the time, philosophical positions rely on our intuitions. Now, those intuitions are shaped by our culture in all sorts of interesting ways. And this is why, another reason why, it's important that we're looking at this ancient philosopher. Not

because we're hunting for parallels, though I hope I've shown that there really are some parallels—both in the sophistic tradition and in the materialistic approach to reality—but also because we want to see the strangeness of other ways of thinking. Why? Because by seeing the strangeness of other ways of thinking, we understand the strangeness of our own.

- 1.52** In the great sweep of the history of Western philosophy, the idea that we're just bits of meat Lego with no soul, and we're just going to be reduced back to the material configurations of atoms from which we came, is a very superstitious belief—very superstitious. Materialism, that way of thinking, it was around in the ancient world, as I explained—but it didn't—certainly in the wake of Plato, was very much a minority position. And yet it's everywhere; it's in the air we breathe. It's not just within the philosophy departments, but it's a very common way of thinking nowadays. So that's part of why we're going back so far, just all the way to the beginning. We're looking at thinking about origins, but we're also thinking about the strangeness of these other ways of thinking.
- 1.53** And we'll see in lecture three that Plato develops a position, particularly in the Republic but also elsewhere, that is effectively our way of thinking today, upside down. The science stuff, the science knowledge, is the least stable—not least because it's always changing. Would you be happy if your teachers at school had been giving you physics textbooks from the 1930s? Plato's—our understanding of the natural, our scientific understanding, of the world is changing the whole time. Would you be happy if your teachers at school were giving you Plato's Dialogues? Well, I hope you would be. Certainly by the end of this series, I hope you would be. You can read those profitably. You can understand and argue with ancient thinking in this way.
- 1.54** So philosophy doesn't evolve in, it doesn't evolve in the same way as the sciences. And what that means is you can have "dinner parties with the dead." I'm going to encourage you in these lectures to have "dinner parties with the dead." And reading a Platonic dialogue is very like that. You're reading the Symposium, you're actually at a dinner party, a drinking party—and things start to get very messy over the course of the evening, as I said earlier, because the drinking is ratcheted up a notch and things get a lot less philosophical over time. Gentleman over there:
- 1.55** Professor, would you consider that today we are in a pre-Socratic epistemological age? And why?
- 1.56** That's an excellent question, and I would say, yes. We are to some extent, in a pre-Socratic intellectual age, inasmuch as: there are dominant orthodoxies that take for granted what the pre-Socratics took for granted, namely that the ultimate shopping list of reality, all the ultimate ingredients that go to make up reality, are physical in some way. Now, today we just say "atoms or the subatomic world." Thales would have said "water molecules," Anaximenes would have said "air molecules," Heraclitus would have said "fire" of some kind. But the point remains, it's ultimately a material, physical way.

"Metaphysics is physics"—there's no "meta" to physics. And you're right, too, to bring in the theological dimension, inasmuch as I think we are, let's say that the elite intellectual culture is very uncomfortable with the idea that the divine might be real. I'm not sure that's true worldwide. In fact, I think we're seeing a resurgence of religion all across the world.

- 1.57** But I think, as it were, within, let's say, a Western establishment, if I can use that phrase, so broad and a bit crude. But broadly speaking, there is a hostility to the idea that there might be more to reality than what science and physics tells us there is.
- 1.58** The pre-Socratics were equally critical of those sorts of ideas. But remember, the pre-Socratics are resisting the kind of theology that Plato himself seems to have resisted. And we'll see in the next lecture how that resistance develops. Because remember that the kind of theology that is being rejected by the pre-Socratics is really a Homeric theology, a rather crude sort of polytheistic and mythological way of thinking about divinity and incredibly anthropomorphic way of thinking about divinity.
- 1.59** If you read that extraordinary opening book of the Iliad, the greatest poem ever written, that extraordinary scene at the end of the first book, when the plague, the arrows of Apollo, are descending on the troops, and suddenly the scene shifts to the top of Mount Olympus, where the gods have gathered for a banquet and the hobbling Hephaestus, the service is supposed to be beautiful, but it's Hephaestus hobbling around, serving the drinks. And unquenchable laughter rose up through the halls of the banquet, up to the ceiling of the banqueting hall. That's an extraordinary moment there. And what Homer is making us understand is this contrast between the grim reality of human mortality, and tragedy, and death, and war, and suffering, and the amorality of Olympus, where the gods live forever at an eternal dinner party. And part of what we see in Plato's Dialogues, and in the pre-Socratics, is a profound skepticism to understanding the divine in that way, and profound skepticism towards the thought that that kind of theology should be what holds, stitches a society together.
- 1.60** Excuse me if I'm zooming things in a bit too much here, but at the beginning of the lecture, you discussed the issue of qualified individuals in their specific field feeling a bit too wise for their own good. Does Plato ever discuss the possibility that perhaps some of that blame lies at the feet of the people who view them as wise in encompassing not just their own field, but in general?
- 1.61** Yes, it's a very good question. I think towards the end of the Republic, you start to see which, as we'll see in lecture five, you start to see Plato addressing this problem by saying, "Well, every group within society with a particular techne, with a particular skill, with a particular talent or aptitude should belong in that place." And it's got a kind of very hierarchical, but also extremely sort of functional way of understanding each individual's contribution to the overall good of society. One of the criticisms he has of democracy is that it's a kind of universal acid for that way of thinking, because he thinks that democratic approaches have a kind of "radical egalitarianism" that makes that kind

of appropriate allocation of different groups to different levels of society—depending on their specialization and depending on their skill—all but impossible. And he thinks that the trade-off for freedom that the democrat, the radical democrat, is willing to make is not worth it because it leads to, in the end, he thinks, to anarchy. It's going to be a very interesting point of discussion and reflection when we come onto that in lecture five.

- 1.62** Yeah so you were talking about how Plato was a sort of, I don't know if the word is fulcrum, but he brought a lot of things together. And obviously in the first lecture you're going to go into the world in which Plato lived and how that influenced him. But how much of Plato was him being influenced by good thinkers and how much of it was him being a product of his time and just having a lot of time to think? Because nowadays we're bombarded with stimulus. Even as recently as the 19th century, you had these big libraries full of books and it seemed like everything was already figured out. How much was figured out when Plato was around?
- 1.63** It's a great question. At one level, very little had been figured out. So if you're thinking in terms of progress in the sciences or in mathematics or even varieties of literature, it's all pretty limited. A lot of it's starting then, but still falls way short of what all those different avenues of human inquiry and achievement would later become. But at another level, what's refreshing about reading the Dialogues is that you understand that all of those enormous libraries in the 19th century, 20th century, 21st century, they're getting bigger and bigger and bigger. In the end, all of that knowledge does still rest on some quite straightforward and simple questions, or at least questions that are deceptively simple, because they are ultimately, they're ultimately philosophical questions.
- 1.64** And so one can always ask of the axioms on which these enormous libraries have been built, books have been written, "Why?" Ultimately, what 's happening here? "What is it to know this? Why pursue this? Is there a good? Is there a good in this field of inquiry? Why do this at all? Why write this book?" So those sorts of philosophical questions they're always opening up—not the bonnet—what do you call a "bonnet" in America? The hood. It's always about "looking under the hood." And looking under the hood is, in fact, it's both an extremely difficult exercise, partly because the questions are so deceptively simple. And those simple questions are difficult, but they're not difficult in the sense that they need to presuppose libraries of knowledge.
- 1.65** Sorry, sorry, I just want a little bit of additional clarification. But what I was trying to get at was also, how much did Plato have to do to be able—how is it that one man can be responsible for so much knowledge descending from him? Is it, because obviously he came up with these fundamentals, but how do you think that he was able to arrive at these fundamentals? Was it on his own, sitting in a cave?
- 1.66** Well so the answer is—it was through endless conversations between people who shared a common passion for understanding and for knowledge. And this was the

foundation of—this is the Peterson Academy. It's the foundation of the First Academy. The academy was a little grove of olive trees just outside Athens dedicated to the hero Academus. Academus—and we'll talk more about the academy there—but that was a place where lectures would happen. Exchange and transmission of knowledge began to assume an institutional form. And that, I think, to answer your, probably answers your question to some extent. This idea that we're going to institutionalize the generation of knowledge, the pursuit of knowledge, and the transmission of knowledge, and over time, that would have enormously beneficial downstream effects for the West. And actually, it's probably in Plato's finest pupil, Aristotle, that we start to really see the birth of fields of inquiry, fields of knowledge, in a way that we don't see with Plato, but Plato, as it were, lays the grounds for that to happen by institutionalizing inquiry and thought.

1.67 Thank you all very much. Looking forward to reconvening for our next lecture.

Lecture 2: Plato's Dialogues

At a glance — The lecture turns to Plato's dialogues as a body of work: their dramatic form, the question of which are early, middle, and late, the role of Socrates as speaker, and why Plato chose dialogue over treatise. Orr considers how the form shapes the philosophy.

- 2.1 So in the last lecture, we looked at Plato's world, his hinterlands, his intellectual hinterlands, his political and cultural backdrop. And now we're going to dive into the Dialogues, his great body of work. He wrote other things. There are letters he wrote—most of them are of dubious authenticity—we're simply not sure if they were really by him. So all we really can confidently say is Plato's work are these Dialogues, conversations, conversations, but not transcripts.
- 2.2 As I said in the first lecture, the Dialogues exhibit a kind of literary flair and quality that are comfortably comparable with Tolstoy, with Samuel Johnson. They're that good, or at least the best of them are that good. The Phaedrus is that good. The Symposium is that good. There are around 35 of them, and there's been a huge amount of scholarly debate over how we organize them, what sort of sequence we think they might have been written in. And I don't want to spend too much time on those debates, because I think they're not so important for us to get a good picture of what's going on in these Dialogues and what their contribution ultimately is to the history of philosophy and to the history of, the history of thought.
- 2.3 The standard way of thinking about the Dialogues, though, is to sort of carve them up roughly into three phases in Plato's career. The early phase, starting from, say, the death of Socrates in 399, which was the kind of catalytic moment where Plato seems to have decided that the only way of really making sure that this great figure, the greatest person who ever lived, in Plato's view, had an afterlife, would be to try to capture his character, his personality, and his ideas in written form. And so I think from this period, the 399, to, let's say, the mid-380s, we have Dialogues that probably capture quite closely the historical Socrates and his style.
- 2.4 They're quite short dialogues. And what's probably most interesting about these Dialogues is that they are failures. Almost all of them end in failure. The Greek word for failure that I'm thinking of is "aporia". So "poreia" is a pathway in Greek. And often when you see an "alpha" or an "a" at the beginning of a Greek word or word in English, influenced by the Greek, it has a negative force. It's called the "alpha privative". So the "aporia" is a kind of, it's a cul-de-sac. Get into a place where you just, there's no way out. There's no way out.
- 2.5 And a lot of these early Dialogues end in a kind of paralysis. At one point, one of the characters in the Dialogue, says, "Socrates, you're like a stingray. You're like a stingray. I thought I knew what this virtue was about. I'm a general, and I thought I knew what courage was. I'm a poet, I thought I knew what literary inspiration was, and now I'm

numb. You've stung me, and I don't know what to do." And you can sometimes see in that kind of comic frustration a genuine resentment, genuine resentment of what Socrates could reduce the great and the good to. So these early Dialogues, they're often brief and they end in failure—"Aporia". They are so-called Aporetic Dialogues.

2.6 But it's almost always an instructive failure. And I want to suggest that the failure is the point. Sometimes it's when you lose an argument or you get to the point in an argument where you're not really sure who's won and you're just not sure what anybody's talking about, that you realize that this is actually a moment of illumination. "Gosh, this assumption that I've been living with my whole life is actually not defensible. In fact, I'm not sure I've got any grounds for thinking that this is true at all." And that is one of the great gifts of thinking philosophically, of thinking critically, of realizing that actually, if you really try to unpack it, it would end in a kind of failure. And therefore something has gone wrong along the way. Something needs fixing, or maybe it's a completely new paradigm needs to be adopted.

2.7 So some of these Dialogues—we'll go into them in a moment—but I just want to just give us a very quick bird's eye view. So we've got the early Dialogues that, as I said, short, tend to end in failure. Then in the 380s, 370s, we start to, as it were, Plato reaches the peak of his genius as a philosopher. And here I'm thinking of Dialogues like the *Phaedo*. When I say the *Phaedo* or when I say the *Euthyphro* or use the word *Phaedrus*, I'm, by the way, using the name that has been given to the Dialogue because of the, it's named after one of the lead characters. Often not a very, not often a character who doesn't succeed very well in the Dialogue. Sometimes a major, major figure, a major sophist. So that's the standard way of talking about it. So there's the *Phaedo* in the middle period, probably the greatest meditation on the soul and on the existence of the soul ever written. Whether we have a soul, what is it? Are we just bodies? The *Phaedrus*, meditation on beauty. The *Symposium*, meditation on love and truth. And finally, of course, the *Republic*, the greatest and most influential of Plato's Dialogues. That's going to occupy us for much of the next lecture and the lecture after that.

2.8 In these Dialogues, we see a definite change. They're longer. They are very often made up of longer speeches by Socrates, as opposed to the kind of back-and-forth, line-by-line disputations that you get, disputation style, argumentative style that you get in the earlier Dialogues. And they generally, even if they don't end in success, you can see that in the long speeches, Socrates is and, Plato, through Socrates, is starting to establish certain claims that we can begin to say, "Yes, this is a Platonic vision of the world."

2.9 And then in the third phase this is really where Plato is starting to reach his 60s and 70s—so 360s, 350s—dies in 347. We get the so-called later Dialogues. And these are often interesting because Socrates as a figure, recedes this one Dialogue where he doesn't appear at all. And other figures start to emerge. In one of them, the *Parmenides*, as I

mentioned in the previous lecture, Socrates is beaten, Socrates is defeated. And actually, Plato seems to be defeated too, because Socrates is defending one of Plato's signature positions.

- 2.10** So that's the broad makeup. That's how we would spread the 35 Dialogues out. But there's a dramatic energy and a dramatic quality to all of them. All of them are fizzing with insights and brimming with new ways of thinking about problems. And so what I want to do in this lecture is the impossible, which is to give you a taste of as many of them as I can. I'm not going to be able to do that. I'm not going to be able to do that, come even close to that for all 35. But I want, by moving through things very quickly in this lecture, moving across the Dialogues very quickly in this lecture, just to give you, to give you a sense of the corpus, the body of work that makes up Plato's achievement. Because in lecture three and in lecture four, we're going to be drilling down into the detail of his ideas. And we'll be moving away from the form in which he expresses those ideas.
- 2.11** Okay, phase one, the early stage—390s, 380s— the aftershock of Socrates' death. Well, there's a kind of trio of Dialogues. There's a trio of Dialogues—the Apology, the Crito, and the Phaedo—that all take place effectively on the day of Socrates' trial, or the second day of Socrates' trial and his forced execution. The Apology, his long speech in defense of his life, of his life's work, his defense of philosophy, his defense of his ignorance. The Crito, which is a Dialogue in which his friends try to persuade him to, "Run away, escape, choose exile, nobody's going to mind." And the third Dialogue, the Phaedo, in which he takes the hemlock and slowly dies over the course of the Dialogue. Now, the Phaedo, I think, is probably, as I said, in the middle period, but we can think in dramatic terms about those three coming together. As I said, the Apology is the one I would start with if I were you. You can pick it up anywhere and all lots of very good translations of it and lots of good audio versions of it, too, which often captures the drama very, very nicely as you're reading along.
- 2.12** Other early Dialogues tend to focus on one particular idea or virtue or problem, and in it we see Socrates constantly working like a gadfly or like a stingray, constantly prodding and pressing and turning and attacking different attempts to define "x". In the Euthyphro Dialogue, "x" is "ta hosion," the holy, piety. What is—ti este—"ta hosion"? What is "the holy"? In the Charmides, it's "Ti este sophrosyne?" What is moderation? What is temperance? In the Laches, it's "Ti este andreia?" What is courage? What is bravery? In the Lysis—what is "philia"? What is friendship? In the Hippias Major, what is beauty? Is it utility? Is it just pleasure? Or is it something more than that?
- 2.13** And all of these Dialogues are just wonderful to read, and they're quite easy to read and fun to read, but they follow the same kind of pattern. And that pattern goes roughly as follows: Socrates ends up in a house or out in the open, finding some, seeking out some expert. We saw this already in that speech, that extract I read out in the first lecture from the Apology, saying, "Well, I want to know what courage is.

Wouldn't it be good to know what courage is? Wouldn't it be good for a society to be, to know what courage is? Or what do I do? If I want to know what courage is, I go to a general. Surely I go to an expert in courage, and who could know more about courage than somebody who's risen up through the ranks and fought the Persian Wars and the Peloponnesian War, than a general?" So the Laches involves Socrates pursuing this poor old general and asking him endlessly, "But tell me, what is courage?"

2.14 And normally the Dialogue will open with a very confident statement, a confident answer from the expert about what "x" is—what courage is, what moderation is, what piety is—and that speech will, as it comes to an end, Socrates always thanks the expert. "I'm so pleased that I came to ask you about this problem because I knew when I came to ask you about this problem that I would get a speech, an answer of that kind of quality. Thank you. But I've just got one little question, one little thing that doesn't quite make sense."

2.15 In the Laches, for example, he says, "You said that courage is endurance, the capacity to endure." "Yes." "But I think you also said, very wisely, in my view, that courage is a virtue." "Of course." "But is it always virtuous to have endurance? Well, what if someone liked to drink or liked to gamble? Would we want the gambler to endure the consequences of his gambling? And would we want to call that virtuous?" "Well, that's not at all what I meant, Socrates. Not at all what I meant." "Oh, so when you said that courage is endurance, you meant that it's not always endurance." "Well, okay. Yet I accept that it's not always endurance." "But if it's not always endurance, then how can endurance be a definition? How can endurance be the essence of courage? And how can we say that you've answered my question, what is courage? I want to know what it is. "Ti este?" I want to know what its DNA is, what its essence is."

2.16 And so the Dialogue unfolds and the general gets more and more frustrated. And Socrates never gets his answer, nor does he venture one. He doesn't even attempt to offer one. But he's exposing ignorance, and he's exposing ignorance in those very corners of society in which society expects to find the answer. Or expects to see the virtue best exemplified and therefore presumably best understood. He's the general. I mean, who else is going to know more about courage? He's the person who's obsessed with religion, who else is going to know more about the holy and piety and so on.

2.17 It's worth just pausing at this point and staying with the question of essence. This is what Socrates is after, and in the end, it's what Plato would be after, too. And Plato's answer, as we'll see in the next lecture, is a theory that the essence of something, in the end, consists in its form or some ultimate ingredient that Plato seemed to think lay beyond space and time and existed in a kind of eternal, timeless way. It's not clear that that was Socrates' view, but there are hints of it in these early Dialogues.

2.18 So the assumption is that there is an answer to the question. What is moderation? What is courage? What is holiness? What is beauty? That there is some correct answer. And that answer is just is the essence of that virtue, that notion. That is fundamentally

antithetical to the postmodern orthodoxies of the modern age. Essence and essentialism—a way of thinking about the world that involves assuming that it's structured in some way by things that have essences, are endowed with essences—is an almost heretical way of thinking. Because it's saying that there are certain objective realities in the world that are stable, that are not open to endless interpretation, that you can be wrong about. Most controversially, of course, this question of essence turns on, is where the question of essence turns on what it is to be human. And what we see, particularly in the post war period, is an attack on the idea that human beings are anything, that there is a way to be human.

2.19 Jean-Paul Sartre, in the wake of the Second World War, delivers an extraordinary lecture called "L'existentialisme est un humanisme". Existentialism is a humanism, or rather, existentialism and humanism— very short little lecture, you can look it up online—it's a fascinating document in the history of modern philosophy. And in this lecture, he says that "the days of essence and of thinking about the world in terms of essences are over. What we need now is to start our philosophical inquiries not with Plato's obsession with essence, but with a focus on existence. Because that's what we can be sure about. I'm more sure that I exist than that I have an essence. I am more sure that I am than I am sure about what I am. And even if I was sure about what I am, I would then risk forcing others to sign up to what it is to be me, and therefore what it is to be them. And that would be coercive. And that way leads to tyranny into fascism." This is the kind of undertone. Sartre is saying, "We need to get rid of all philosophy from Plato to me, with a few exceptions along the way, maybe Nietzsche, maybe Heidegger. All attempts to think of the world as ordered and structured by stable realities, stable essences. We need to stop thinking about reality as being given to us, as given rather than invented. We invent, we don't discover."

2.20 And so the existentialist tradition defines itself—the reason the word existence is in there—is because it's defining itself against essentialism. And it sees essentialism as beginning with Plato and in particular with the Socrates of these early Dialogues, with the assumption that philosophical inquiry begins in a way that it can end. That philosophy involves, philosophical inquiry involves, searching for a quarry that is really there. And the point of these early Dialogues is not to find the quarry, necessarily, or to show or argue what the quarry is, but it is to say that there's a quarry out there and we've not found it yet. And look at the failures that come along the way as we try and find this quarry. And that basic assumption—that there's an end to philosophical inquiry, there is a way that in principle, there's a way in principle in which this discussion, this argument can be resolved—is one that the postmodern tradition—which, of course, encompasses a whole variety of thinkers, many of whom disagreed with each other appropriately, though, given their starting assumptions, weren't able to claim that they had a monopoly on the truth—but that entire phase in the postwar period—through the 50s and the 60s—begins with this skepticism that Socrates was right to ask the question in a way that assumed that there could be an answer.

- 2.21** The Euthyphro Dialogue, like the Laches, involves pursuing a quarry, and that quarry is piety, devotion, holiness. And Socrates runs rings around this poor young man on his way to sue his father. Suing his father for failing to look after one of his slaves. And he's doing this because he thinks that this is the pious thing to do, what the gods would have wanted. And so Socrates also says, "You must therefore be an expert on piety. You must be an expert on holiness and what the gods want. Seeing as you seem so clear that the gods, in knowing what the gods want you to do in this context, pretty shocking context." And the Dialogue unfolds and it becomes immediately clear. This young man has got no idea what holiness is, what piety is.
- 2.22** Socrates ends up asking him, after looking at his definition of, "well, the holy, piety, is whatever the gods love. That's piety." Socrates says, "So, do the gods love what is holy because it's holy, or is the holy holy because the gods recognize it, say that it's holy? Are the gods recognizing holiness, or are they stipulating holiness? Which is it?" And Euthyphro simply can't answer this question. His instinct is to say, "Well, of course, piety is just whatever the gods love, the gods love. And that's what we should do. That's what should frame how we conduct ourselves in relation to them, whatever the gods love."
- 2.23** And Socrates sees that there's a real problem here, particularly if we're talking about the gods of Homer's pantheon, of the Iliad. I said earlier about, in the previous lecture, about the way that extraordinary, the extraordinary pathos at the end of book one of the Iliad, where the gods are shown to be completely indifferent to human suffering. And what they love is certainly not the flourishing of all human beings, it's just the flourishing of their own, their favorites. So part of what the Euthyphro is doing is developing a critique of civic religion, of the Homeric gods, and of Greek mythology as a repository for truth and for ideas that conform us in virtue, conform our character, because it just seems, why would we want to listen to those gods? Why would we want to love what they love? Why would we want to conduct ourselves and think of piety as a virtue, as a virtue that is centered around the moral character of these gods?
- 2.24** What Socrates starts—and this is my own view of the Euthyphro—is that he's pushing Euthyphro to the point where he is forcing him to say, that actually even the gods have to recognize what's good and beautiful and true. And even the gods must and can be judged by what they love. We can say that something is good and beautiful and true because it's good and beautiful and true, and not because the gods happen to think, just think that this is what's good and this is what's beautiful and this is what's true.
- 2.25** And I think what you see here is an early foreshadowing of Plato's so-called Theory of Forms. Now, there's a problem with that phrase—which I'll go into in the next lecture—but let's just say what we see here is a foreshadowing of the idea that the good and the beautiful and the true are objective realities that we discover and we don't invent, and that even the gods discover and don't invent. It's not up to Zeus what's good. It's not up to Zeus what's beautiful and it's not up to Zeus what's true.

- 2.26** It's not an accident, I don't think, that this Dialogue is also one of what I call the trial Dialogues. It's happening, Socrates is in the area of the courts because—where he meets this guy about to go and sue his father—because he's about to go on trial. And I think there's a sort of dramatic message in the Dialogue. And I think what Plato is saying here is that you can see how threatening Socrates' questions were. You can see how destabilizing these sorts of ideas were. You can start to make sense of that strange accusation—one of the two that he's put on trial for—he's introducing new gods. He's not comfortable with Zeus anymore. He's saying that, he's talking about these other things, just "the good", "the beautiful", "the true", as being more real, as being realities that even Zeus and the other Olympian gods and the gods that sustain Athenian civic religion and social order and justice that even they must answer to and respect.
- 2.27** So it's a wonderful little read. I remember being made to read it as an undergraduate university in the original Greek. And my goodness, it took a long time and I had a lot of headaches coming from it, because it's what's holy holy because the gods love it, or is it, and it's "ta hestia tois theois," and so on and so on. It got maddening. But I look back on that time now and I think that was an amazing opening to philosophy for me. At the time, it made me decide never to study philosophy again. And from the age of 20-27, I read no philosophy because of that Dialogue. Other reasons, too, "Guys, just what is he talking about here?" And I started to steer well clear of it and towards history and literature and then law.
- 2.28** But I look back on it now with great affection. And what's fascinating about it, as I said, it's a text that doesn't teach you anything about, in terms of actual philosophical claims. What it shows is how little we often know. What it shows is that some of the central assumptions of a culture or of a society—not just any old assumptions, but assumptions that are the glue for a society that stitch and hold a society together—may be assumptions and ideas that we've got no idea about at all. We've got no notion of what these claims might involve, what part of reality they are anchored in, whether they track truth. So those are some of the early Dialogues.
- 2.29** As we move into the middle period. We start, as I said, to see some of Plato's greatest achievements. Here we've got the Protagoras, the Gorgias, Mino, Phaedo, Symposium, Phaedrus, Republic. Protagoras is the name of one of the great sophists of the 5th century, Protagoras of Abdera, extremely sophisticated thinker. And the Dialogue involves a very young Socrates coming to ask Protagoras some questions, ending up at a house. And the opening scene, where Socrates is welcomed into the foyer, is described like Odysseus going down into Hades. It's a famous scene in book eleven of Homer's Odyssey, which Odysseus goes down into the underworld. Plato plays with this imagery of Socrates walking into the Hades of the sophists, the Hades of sophistry.
- 2.30** And over the course of this Dialogue, Socrates' relentless questioning and use of dialectic, his kind of gentle irony and his ridicule, exposes the sophist present as being obsessed with money, with power, with influence and so on. And in the end, actually,

Protagoras is pretty good natured, he even compliments Socrates. He says, "Maybe one day, I think one day you're going to be very eminent in philosophy. You've got real talent, you've got real promise." But he's so fed up and exhausted by the argumentative beating he's taken from Socrates that he withdraws.

2.31 The Protagoras is often paired with the Gorgias, extraordinary Dialogue. And I would say after the Apology, the one Dialogue, the other Dialogue that you should start with, I always recommend people start with this gorgeous Gorgias, gorgeous Dialogue. He's another famous sophist. What's interesting about the way he's presented in this Dialogue compared to Protagoras, in the Protagoras, is that Socrates has a great deal of time for Gorgias. He's presented more sympathetically. And there's a certain sadness about him too. He talks early on in the Dialogue, he's saying, "I've been looking for this. I've been looking for an order, I've been looking for answers, but I just don't feel I've found it." So there is a kind of sort of an honesty about Gorgias that puts him in quite a favorable light. But then one of his students comes in, Polus, and starts arguing with Socrates in a very aggressive way, but in a very unproductive and unsuccessful way.

2.32 And we start to see, and we see portrayed the consequences of sophistic pedagogy, the consequences of the sophist's approach to teaching the young and the damage that it can do, instilling false confidence and dogmatism and aggression and obsession with rhetorical wordplay. And it's very clear that Gorgias has failed as a teacher. And we're encouraged always to see philosophy and philosophical dialogue as a form of teaching, often mutual teaching. Each side is learning more as they get close in their mutual collaboration to finding the truth. And it's often interesting, I think, that we often can't tell the difference between Socrates and Plato because it's not as simple as just teacher and student. There's a lot happening in between teacher and student that can't really be assigned to either. It's not really the responsibility of either. It's something that arises through the exchange between teacher and student.

2.33 We saw this in the questions and the exchanges at the end of the first lecture. There's a question, I try to give an answer, but then there was sort of back and forth. The questions shed more light, or maybe try to point out where there was some darkness and we needed more light. But what we see here in the Gorgias is the failure of teaching and the consequences of that failure. Many of the figures who pop up in these Dialogues were—after the Dialogues, after the dramatic date of the Dialogues—involved in some of the worst events and developments in the slow disintegration of Athens as a political power in the 5th century, a collapse from democracy into oligarchy and eventually tyranny. Through a series of catastrophic decisions, partly catalyzed by demagogic figures who had learned the art of rhetoric from the sophists, including, in Plato's view, the decision to put Socrates on trial and to force his death.

2.34 The Gorgias ends with the explosion onto the scene of this figure, Callicles. And he's a chilling figure, Callicles. He gives a beautiful speech about the importance of power. It's beautifully expressed in the Greek. It's compelling. It's like Edmund in King Lear, or

Raskolnikov in Crime and Punishment, or Milton's Satan, "Evil, be thou my good." This sort of, the terrifying splendor and beauty that the poet or the novelist can give to evil. And we see this in the figure of Callicles and Callicles' argument that really justice is nothing but the advantage, the pursuit of the advantage of the stronger party. That what right is really deep down is might, only might makes right. And power is what determines morality.

- 2.35** This logic—the logic of "might makes right"—comes back right at the beginning of another middle Dialogue—the greatest Dialogue Plato ever wrote—the Republic. The first book of the Republic, has a figure similar to Callicles, advancing the same argument, same sorts of arguments as Callicles does in the Gorgias. They're sort of paired Dialogues in many ways. And this logic for Plato and for Socrates, in my view, was so terrifying and recognized to be so destabilizing politically and socially, that it required the remaining nine books of the Republic to explore why it was wrong and what the alternative should be.
- 2.36** There was a famous incident, an infamous incident, that haunts this passage in the Gorgias and the first book of the Republic, which happened in 415 BC on the island of Milos, just south of Athens. And it's described with terrifying precision in Book 5 of Thucydides' history of the Peloponnesian War. Thucydides is often thought of as the father of history. Herodotus, if Herodotus is the father of anthropology, Thucydides is the father of history, the first historian. Not a chronicler, a historian, somebody who thinks not just in some sort of itemized shopping list way about past events, but trying to think about the meaning of history and the power of history to educate us about the future and to help us diagnose the present.
- 2.37** And in this passage in Book 5, he describes Athenian ambassadors being sent from Athens to the island of Milos, demanding tribute submission from the island to Athens in its efforts to protect all the Greek islands and city-states from an increasingly, let's say, a receding threat from the Persian Empire. There's a bid for Athenian power in that part of the Mediterranean. And the logic that unfolds in these speeches that Thucydides puts into the mouths of the Athenian delegates is exactly the logic that we see in evidence in Callicles, in the Gorgias, and in the figure of Thrasymachus in Book 1 of the Republic.
- 2.38** "Look, you may, you Milians, value your independence, value the flourishing of your own community, and you may indeed think that it is just for us to leave you alone. But you don't have the navy we do. You don't have the resources we do. You don't have the power that we do. And justice is, "dikaioné" is, what we tell you it is. Justice is what we want you to do. "Phósun phéron tou khraitérou," the advantage of the stronger, as Thrasymachus puts it in Book 1 of the Republic.
- 2.39** This idea that power is the ultimate horizon, self-interest is the ultimate horizon of all human action and social order, is probably, I'd say, one of the two or three most threatening ideas that Plato wants to diffuse and counter. But let me add a qualifier

here. It's fashionable to think these days, after Michel Foucault and others, that power is the problem. It's just power is the problem. Whether it's the patriarchy, the power of the patriarchy, or the power of white supremacy or the power of fascism, the power of this that needs to be exposed and unmasked. There should be no power is the thought. Institutions are the illegitimate repository of power, and we shouldn't have that. So goes the logic.

- 2.40** That is not what Plato is pushing for, as we'll see in the next lecture—I'm sorry, in lecture five, lecture four—when we look at Plato on politics. He's not saying there should be no power, in fact, some of Plato's greatest critics said he was too obsessed with coercive mechanisms in the state and too obsessed with making sure power was wielded to take him seriously as a political philosopher or to want to push his ideas in political philosophy. We'll come on to that when we do in lecture four. I just want to flag this important point that the concern is not about power in itself.
- 2.41** When you're in the dentist's chair, you are not going to accuse the dentist of oppressing your molars. You are not going to claim that you're a victim, that there's an appalling asymmetry in the distribution and dispersal of power within society between dentists and their patients. There is, in every single context we find ourselves in today, in day-to-day life, an appropriate structure for power. Whether it's coming to lectures and listening to people talk about Plato, whether it's taking driving lessons, whether it's just walking into a cafe and acknowledging the different functions of the different people within the cafe, the coffee shop. That's not the problem. Plato is, in fact, has an incredibly sophisticated and fine-grained understanding of how these different power relations should be organized within the state. And he may be wrong about that, but he doesn't just think that the solution is to just get rid of power completely.
- 2.42** What he's most worried about in late 5th century Athens, as was uncovered at that incident in Milos in 415— which ended, by the way, in the slaughter of all adult males on that island and the enslavement of all women and children, fellow Greeks, but because they would not submit to Athens, might was exercised, and it was thought to be right. So what we see in that, what we see in the Gorgias, what we see in the 1st Book of the Republic what he's worried about there is the idea that power is the ultimate horizon, the power of self-interest, power in itself, power that is not anchored in the good, in justice, that is not anchored— and mediated through the beautiful, power that is not anchored in what is true and what is real. That's what he's worried about.
- 2.43** As we'll see in the remaining Books of the Republic, he thinks that once you've trained yourself to grasp the good, and you've worked out a way in which society can train its best and brightest to grasp the good and to grasp justice, once you're there, then you can start to organize society in a way in which power relations are appropriately structured and constellated.
- 2.44** I promised that I would go through as many of the Dialogues as I could, and we've barely got through 6 or 7. There are lots more that I could have talked about. I could

have talked about the *Phaedo*, I touched on it briefly. This extraordinary argument for the claim that biological death is not death, that you are eternal, you are ensouled. You have a soul that has a body, that the biological death, that is, say, the death of the body is not the death of the soul. Socrates advances 3 or 4 very famous arguments for that claim in an effort— not just because he thought they were true—but also in an effort to console his friends, because the arguments occur just as he's drinking, he develops the arguments as he's drinking the hemlock. And as his walking starts to slow down and his words start to slur and he's arguing that his soul is beginning to depart from his body.

- 2.45 It's an extraordinary moment in Western literature. It's an extraordinary work of Western literature, as well as being one of the most interesting and endlessly fascinating arguments for one side of one of the most difficult philosophical questions, namely the mind-body problem. Sometimes today called the hard problem of consciousness. What is consciousness?
- 2.46 We could have looked at the *Symposium*, too, one of the greatest meditations and discussions of love as a kind of yearning for knowledge and as a yearning for the transcendent. For the claim that the lover's love for the beloved is not an egocentric desire, but a desire for the improvement, the betterment of the beloved. And that the lover's love for the beloved is also a love somehow for the beautiful and the good and the truth that is exemplified in the beloved, or that lies in the potential of the beloved. As the lover's love for the beloved develops and can form and draw out that potency. It's an extraordinary and mesmerizing series of exchanges. There are the later *Dialogues*, too, and we'll touch on those in subsequent lectures, but I've talked a little bit already about the *Parmenides*.
- 2.47 But there's also the *Timaeus*, which is an extraordinary and insightful *Dialogue* describing Plato's understanding of the cosmos and its ordering, and in particular, the role that a godlike figure plays in structuring nature. Now, this is quite an obscure text of Plato's. It's a late text, but it so happened that it became one of the most influential *Dialogues* in the West for about a thousand years, from roughly 500 AD to 14, the late 15th century, when many of the other *Dialogues* began to be rediscovered. Very influential commentaries on the *Timaeus* and it's partly because in the *Timaeus* we see something like a doctrine of creation. Something like a godlike figure ordering the world, designing the world, investing it with purposiveness, with a "telos," the demiurge. The demiurge is not the God of Abrahamic monotheism. He's not the God of Genesis, but he's a pretty thick slice of God. He's a thick slice of the divine, and certainly too thick a slice of the divine for the atheist digestive system.
- 2.48 There's a big question as to how mythological it's supposed to be understood, the divine activity described in the *Timaeus*. But you can see why it's a *Dialogue* that was so popular and had such influence and impact on the Abrahamic traditions, particularly the Christian one, but also Islam, in the golden era of Islam under the Abbasid Caliphate in the last quarter of the first millennium.

- 2.49 Good. Now, in the next lecture, we're going to move on to think more deeply about the Republic, and we're going to move away from the Dialogues themselves. We're going to start looking at the central kind of engine rooms of Plato's thought, looking at the problem of being and the problem of knowing. But for now, let's end this lecture on Dialogues with some dialogue. Questions? Comments, heckles? Yes.
- 2.50 Power ought to be anchored in the good and the beautiful and the true, and the good and the beautiful and the true is explored through dialogue with one another and through being comfortable in ignorance, in a society that has lost the ability to do that with one another, how ought we to move forward in learning how to restore dialogue so that good power can come back into play?
- 2.51 That's a great question, and it's one that will occupy us a lot in the next lecture. And I would say that Plato's answer to that is openness to dialogue. So he thinks that what characterizes a society that has got itself into that, the kind of paralysis you describe, is an unwillingness to engage in dialogue, or simply a tolerance of what amounts to nothing more than a dialogue of the deaf. And we'll see in the great image of the Republic in Book 7 of the Republic, the way in which Plato describes this. So the society that you describe in that question is the society of prisoners in chains in a cave, mesmerized by the flickering flames on the back wall of the cave. And maybe talking about it and talking about the flames and forming theories about the pictures that emerge from the flickering flames on the back of the wall of the cave. But it's not proper dialogue. It's not dialogue that is, it's a dialogue that's obsessed with mythos, not logos. To use an important pair of terms, "mythos" is story. Narrative. "Logos" is reason, justification, what anchors a mythos in the true.
- 2.52 A lot of the exchanges I've had with Dr. Peterson have involved my complaining that he doesn't think hard enough about locating and anchoring the mythos in the logos. And he thinks I don't think enough about making sure that the mythos can convey a lot of the power of the logos. And it's been fascinating to see the evolution of his thinking about those two. I mean, part of his fascination for Jung is that you've got these almost Platonic archetypes, logoi, logos, that Jung thinks were common to all human beings, but exemplified in distinct and particular ways through different mythoi, through different stories. But that the claim is those different stories from different cultures have a kind of cross-cultural underlying logos that can be discerned and discovered and organized, helps us to understand what it is to be human in a more profound way. Yes.
- 2.53 Just to add on to her question, what do you think, in a philosophical way, really destroyed our ability to have dialogue?
- 2.54 Well, there are many possible answers to that. I would just jump back to our first lecture. So, two of the mindsets that undermine proper true truth-seeking dialogue would be, one, the idea that there are just multiple truths, that truths can be fragmented between partners in a dialogue, and even if those truths clash, can still be held as true. You can see why that just kills all possible motivation for continuing in the

exercise to find capital "T" Truth, if you just don't think there's any such thing as capital "T" Truth. Or if you just think that the search for truth is really just a mask for power, or the claim that one's arrived at the truth is really just an attempt to coerce those who aren't signed up to it.

- 2.55** The other thought—this is probably a third explanation of why we've got to where we've got, why we've got to the paralysis we've got to—is the idea that there's just no truth at all, that truth is ultimately maybe an evolutionary strategy to get ahead. It's just a "survival of the fittest" issue. As Richard Dawkins put it, "DNA neither knows nor cares. DNA just is, and we dance to its music." We're not looking for truth. DNA is not interested in truth. It's interested in replicating itself. So if you take that very hard-boiled scientific approach, or reductively scientific approach, roughly, the idea that all truths have to be scientific truths, and that the ultimate story of human origins and development is an evolutionary Darwinian one, the ultimate story and the comprehensive story, then what does truth even mean? We're not seeking truth. We're not beings, souls seeking truth. We are a species seeking survival. And sometimes the characteristics that help us survive will not be conducive to truth. Sure, sometimes it's going to help, if you know that there are 2 tigers in one valley and 2 tigers in the other valley. The tribe that can count is going to do better than the tribe that can't.
- 2.56** But sometimes there will be systematically false sets of beliefs that also confer survival value. After all, what was the claim of the new atheists 15 years ago for the explanation of why there's religion at all if it's just fairy stories and fakery? Well, there must have been some survival benefits. Maybe just thinking that you're a soul who's going to live forever is going to console you in the face of immense grief. It's an evolutionary strategy. Grief doesn't mean anything, it's just useful to help you survive. There are false beliefs that help you survive, but truth has not got anything to do with it. It's just survival is the only currency.
- 2.57** So I'd say that, so those three, no capital "T" Truth, capital "P" Power, and evolutionary, a scientific reduction of all truth seeking to survival seeking. There are more, but I would say those are the three big explanations for why it's so hard to have the kind of dialogues that Plato is encouraging us to have. Lady, here.
- 2.58** So in today's world, where there's a lot of poor role models and high power positions and anyone could kind of become an expert on anything, who can people look up to when you kind of realize that no one really knows anything?
- 2.59** Yeah, it's a very good question. The idea of a moral exemplar, the idea that learning how to be good and forming oneself in the kind of school of virtue involves not just working out some theory or achieving success in some philosophical dialogue, but watching another person is a very powerful one. Now, we see this most often in religious traditions, particularly in the Catholic tradition and Orthodox traditions of the saints. This idea that the lives of the saints, or the lives of the martyrs that these

convey, have an enormous power to help us live up to the best in us. But we also, I think, see it in Plato's Dialogues. So I think we see it in the figure of Socrates.

2.60 And we're invited to think of Socrates not just as a brilliant thinker, but in Dialogues particularly, like the *Phaedo* and in the *Apology*, in those last two or three days of his life, somebody who led an exemplary life and confronted death in a way that everyone, anyone would want to have the strength to confront death. For answers over, "What do we do about our present predicament?" Well, I think recognize that moral exemplars and the desire and the appetite always to look to others and take moral cues from others is persistent and pervasive and perennial, and that it matters, therefore, who we elevate. That is something I think we can all agree on.

2.61 But as you say, the sources of kind of authority that would determine who is to be elevated and who isn't have now been just so fragmented by the digital revolution, by globalization and so on, that it's very hard to get a firm grip on what counts as a saint today. We still have saints, and there are secular saints, think of Martin Luther King Day, or think of Gandhi or Nelson Mandela. There's still that, as I said, perennial instinct to say, "That's something we should live up to," and that's a good thing. Gentleman, you wanted to ask from the previous lectures.

2.62 Yes. We spoke about science and philosophy as different systems. You can prove things in science, and you cannot prove them in the same way as philosophy. We also mentioned that science is always changing, so sometimes we make a mistake. So, obviously, correct me if I'm wrong on this assumption, it would be very difficult to inform philosophy using science because of the fact that it's always changing. So my question is, is it possible, and should we do the opposite? Should we inform science with philosophy?

2.63 That's a great question. Thank you. And you picked me up on something I should have been clearer about. I'm not sure you can even use, I'm not even comfortable with the phrase "scientific proof". As I said, we wouldn't be happy, you shouldn't be happy if you've been given physics textbooks from the 1930s. Right? But if science is about proofs, then doesn't matter when they come from, the proofs are proofs. In mathematics, you get proofs. You get theorems in mathematics. You get theories in science. So I'd say even there's a sort of difference. And then in philosophy, I suppose you get theories, but there's simply no way of testing hypotheses, thought experiments and so on, possibly.

2.64 But to answer your question, should it be the case, and how could it be the case, that philosophy informs science? Well, at the moment, it's about science informing philosophy. I mean, one of Stephen Hawking's last books on the opening page says, effectively, "Philosophy now is nothing more than the backseat driver to science and cosmology. The proper business of the philosopher is to comment a little on the discoveries of the sciences." And I think that is just a profoundly misguided view. And it's profoundly misguided in part because one discovery in the sciences had an

extraordinary impact on philosophy, and that was the Hawking-Penrose singularity theorem, which had a very interesting knock-on effect within the philosophy of religion when it came to the so-called Kalam Cosmological Argument, which begins from the premise that the universe began to exist. Before the 1960s, before that theorem was established, you just couldn't really start from that premise.

2.65 But I think philosophy informs science inasmuch as science is invested and presupposes certain values—values of cooperation, of truth seeking, of public benefit, of reasonableness. These are of epistemic modesty. These are not scientific things, they are values. They are drawn from the world of moral philosophy. And whether scientists are aware of it or not, they have these values, they invest their inquiries, they begin their inquiries, they conduct their inquiries with these non-scientific, say, "philosophical" ways of thinking about virtue, collaboration, truth, modesty, and so on.

Lecture 3: Plato's Theories

At a glance — Orr surveys Plato's central theories — the Forms, knowledge versus opinion, the tripartite soul, and the theory of recollection — showing how the metaphysics, epistemology, and psychology interlock into a single vision.

- 3.1 In the first lecture, we did a whistle-stop tour of Plato's hinterlands, his intellectual backdrop, his cultural influences, the political context. And then in the second lecture, we did a very, very quick tour de raison of Plato's Dialogues. We didn't cover even half of them, but I just wanted to give you a taste of what they offer and a sense of the overall arc of Plato's intellectual career, from the earlyaporetic failed Dialogues, the shorter Socratic Dialogues, through to the middle period, the Republic, the Phaedrus, the Symposium, the Phaedo, and then into the later Dialogues, some of which we'll talk about in this lecture and the next lecture.
- 3.2 What are we doing in this lecture? Well, in this lecture, we're going to zoom out a little bit from the Dialogues and start focusing on Plato's big idea, the animating core of Plato and Platonism, the ideas that would come to turbocharge Western philosophy, and that, as I will try to suggest, are with us still today, even as so many of us would reject them, even as those ideas are rejected by many philosophers today. I want to approach this animating core of Plato negatively—we're going to take a *via negativa*. We're going to try and illuminate, by contrast, what Plato was on about by setting out some "isms" today that would largely define themselves by rejecting Platonism and Plato's animating idea.
- 3.3 We've seen some of them already. Remember, we talked in the first lecture about the Ionian philosophy, Ionian natural sciences, the tendency to reduce all of reality to material substances. We've also seen in the figure of the sophists, the specter of relativism, the idea that there's no capital "T" truth. Truth is always and everywhere up for grabs.
- 3.4 Now, there are all sorts of instantiations of that in the modern world. In the Ionians, we see today, for example, the fashion for empiricism, empiricism. Empiricism from the Greek "*empeiría hómai*", simply, "I experience" comes to mean a philosophy that grounds itself—that treats as the benchmark for knowledge and reality—what is given in sense experience. So the great figures here in early modern philosophy and Western philosophy would be figures like John Locke, David Hume, and George Berkeley, great British tradition of empiricism. Sense experience first, and a broad suspicion of rationality.
- 3.5 Empiricism is, if you like, Plato, turned upside down. Empiricism puts first what Plato puts last. Why? Why does Plato put it last? He puts it last because he's suspicious of anything that is in a state of constant change. He thinks that true knowledge, as we'll see, is characterized by stability, by something concrete, an anchor that is as necessary

and solid as possible. And he thinks that the world of sense experience, quite rightly, is in a state of constant and continual flux. And he thought that the pre-Socratics and the Ionians and Heraclitus was right about this. But the world of sense experience is just a world of constant Becoming and not Being. We can't get to being through sense experience alone, because all sense experience reveals to us is Becoming.

- 3.6** In the modern world, Becoming is, as it were, all there is. And the natural sciences, the extraordinary successes of the natural sciences, has meant that our culture and our culture's philosophers are suspicious of treating the world of Becoming as somehow downstream of some spooky world of timeless, eternal Being. So that's one of the ways we can illuminate, by contrast, Plato's animating core.
- 3.7** Another ism—constructivism, constructivism. This is more of an epistemological idea. That is to say, it's not so much about the nature of reality, but about what's going on as we engage the world we find ourselves in, what's going on up here, what's going on in terms of our perceptions, what's going on in terms of our cognition, our understanding, and our perception. Constructivism is committed to the idea that, really, our everyday experience is constructed by us, constructed by society. That there is no ultimate meaning, that at least no ultimate meaning that we can access. Meaning is invented, it is not discovered. It's not a matter of aligning ourselves rightly to the way the world actually is. And we shouldn't dismiss constructivism out of hand. It's quite obvious that there are all kinds of structures in the world that are, as it were, made by humans, made by human decision—companies, countries, sport. These are constructions.
- 3.8** But the constructivist wants to go much further. The constructivist wants to say, "No, there is no ultimate scheme of reality or no way of understanding the world that isn't, in the end, reducible to our habits of imposing structures and schemes on reality. There's no way, as it were, of jumping outside our conceptual skin. There's no way of jumping outside our linguistic skin. We're condemned to the world of 'becoming' and talk of 'being' and everything that comes with the world of 'being'—forms, God—is just gibberish." Plato is well aware of this approach, and he is profoundly suspicious of it. He thinks that in the end, it's got to collapse.
- 3.9** He's also very suspicious of the doctrine that we might call positivism. Positivism—the word comes from Auguste Comte, 19th century French philosopher. It's not always clear what positivism is supposed to mean, but roughly, it involves the idea that what you see is what you get. So logical positivism is really just the idea that all there is to language is logic. Everything is to be analyzed in logical terms. Scientific positivism, roughly speaking—hardcore empiricism. What you see "science" is what is what we see "science" is all we've got.
- 3.10** There are other kinds of positivism, too. There's legal positivism. Legal positivism is this dominant idea in contemporary philosophy of law or jurisprudence that there's no law of nature, there's no moral universe out there, or none that we can access or speak of. All we can take our moral cues from, all we can make sense, all we can derive our

obligations from, is what the law tells us. The law is what we've got, and it's positive law, that is to say, the laws passed by Congress or by Parliament or by the courts. There's no deeper morality beyond that. There is no natural law. There is no moral universe that is interwoven with the physical universe.

- 3.11** And finally, there is haunting all understandings of what it is to be human and what it is to flourish as a human being—the theory of evolution. Evolutionary theory, not as merely a plainly plausible and well-supported scientific theory, but as a metaphysic, as a comprehensive framework, an exhaustive framework—the only framework through which we can ultimately understand where we've come from, who we are, and where we're going. We are again on that theory, condemned only to a world of pure Becoming, governed by nothing other than natural selection.
- 3.12** So these, as it were, think of all of those sorts of positions—positivism, constructivism, empiricism, evolutionism—in one corner of the ring. These are the opponents that Plato will be taking on. Plato, one biography tells us, was a very good wrestler. He was broad-shouldered, very good at wrestling. He liked it. And he wasn't just an intellectual wrestler. So this is an appropriate image to be working with.
- 3.13** There's another strain of thinking in contemporary philosophy—contemporary ideas and culture—because philosophy never stops in the seminar room. Philosophy always trickles down to the street. The ideas that we may think are crazy in a philosophy lecture or extreme in some obscure book, may well become the water we're swimming in culturally before too long. And I think that is exactly what we've seen in the last 150 years. So philosophy matters.
- 3.14** This strain of thinking is more about what it is, what's going on, when we're trying to put forward some answer to life's most fundamental questions. And we have here the figures, the so-called figures of the masters of suspicion—three figures. Karl Marx thought that reason is motivated, reason is often just an excuse, deployed by the property-owning classes, the bourgeoisie, to exploit the proletariat—the working classes. Certainly religion and morality are not real. They're just tools, they're instruments to keep in check the poor. Friedrich Nietzsche said: All this talk of morality, of an objective world of values out there, is not a tool or an instrument used by the strong against the weak, but one that's used by the weak against the strong. It's a kind of conspiracy theory invented, emerging from Judaism and from Christianity, and it's a tool that the weak, in the great game of life, use to keep in check the energy and vitalism of the superman. Just as an aside, Marx and Nietzsche, I hope you can see, can't both be right. Either morality and the Platonic illusion is a tool that the strong use to keep and check the weak, or it's a tool that the weak use to keep in check the strong. Or maybe it's neither. Of course, Plato would say it's neither—I just note that contradiction in passing.
- 3.15** Another master of suspicion, Sigmund Freud. There is no, reason doesn't track truth or meaning. Reason is just a disguise for suppressed urges and desires and appetites.

Notice all of these masters of suspicion exempt their own rational conclusions from the acids of their own skepticism. So presumably we're invited, we must say to Freud, "Your skepticism, that all reasoning and all these wonderful books you're producing is in fact simply not to be treated as true, but simply as an expression of your own suppressed desires." Presumably that has to be carved out. But again, I just note that as an aside. So more people to put in the corner of the ring, for the wrestling ring for Plato to confront.

- 3.16** So how does Plato go about this wrestling context? There are many Dialogues in which he develops the so-called Theory of Forms—the Phaedrus, the Meno, in particular, the Symposium, but most of all, and at the greatest length in the Republic—the greatest and certainly the most influential philosophical work ever produced in the West.
- 3.17** But I want to just caution, introduce a note of caution. A Theory of Forms is a very famous idea, but it's not always helpful. There is no theory in the sense that Plato, as I said in the first lecture, doesn't unpack. He doesn't really do theory. He doesn't write books setting out his theory neatly. As I said, he doesn't say anything in his own voice about any theory or any Forms or any ideas. Everything is refracted through the prism of these constantly shifting conversational dynamics, dominated and led by Socrates, but also through the figures of Glaucon in the Republic and Adeimantus in the Republic. Glaucon and Adeimantus are Plato's brothers. He gives his brothers a big role, but he doesn't give himself any. So there's not much of a theory in the sense that we would recognize today.
- 3.18** And Forms and ideas—that language, "ἰδέα" for ideas and "eidos" or "eide", in the plural for "forms," can be misleading too. Because when we think of the word idea, we think of something a little bit ethereal. "It's just an idea I had. It's sort of a passing idea. It's an idea somebody had." There's a sense that it's insubstantial—an idea. And that's misleading, because Plato thought that ideas were more real than rocks, more real than any physical substance, absolutely objective— more real than anything. And we use the language of Forms, but he doesn't really have in mind patterns or geometric forms. It's something quite different. It's a world of objective essences that are immune to the ravages of time and immune to any degeneration that we might find in space. They are, in other words, transcendent, transcendent.
- 3.19** Well, what do we mean by transcendence? It's a tricky word. I've had quite a bit of back and forth with Dr. Peterson on this. He likes to use the word transcendence in, I think, not a completely correct way. It's not, at least not in its normal way. He thinks that we can talk of transcendence, as he likes to think in terms of the psychology of perception. So I'm looking at a light in the corner of a room, and as it were, he wants to say that the light is cutting across my perceptual vision. Like, yes, I am making sense of it through my perceptions. But at the same time, I'm not just constructing that light. The light is real, and somehow it cuts across my perceptual field. It transcends it, as it were. I'm not just constructing it.

- 3.20** And that's a perfectly appropriate use of the word transcendence. But it's not the common way of understanding it. And sometimes he'll slip and slide when I'm talking about transcendence, or Jonathan Pageau will be talking about transcendence, or Stephen Blackwood's talking about transcendence, that's not what we mean. We mean something altogether different. We don't quite mean it, I think. I don't want to speak for all of us, but I don't think we mean it quite in the Platonic sense. But the Platonic sense is much closer to it.
- 3.21** For something to be transcendent in the usual sense is for it to be, to cut across spacetime. Is for something to exist in a way that transcends the World of Becoming, that is just part of the World of Being. Now, this is a difficult idea for us to get our heads around, not least because our heads are in space and time. How do we hook onto something that's not in space and time? We are spatial beings, we're temporal beings, we're spatiotemporal beings. We're creatures of the Big Bang. How could our puny little minds have any grip on what exists independently of the Big Bang and beyond the Big Crunch?
- 3.22** Well, what I want to put before you is what Plato himself insists—all those who aspire to be philosopher rulers, and all those who aspire to membership of his growing academy, must do—maths. They've got to study maths. And I want you just to think of a very simple mathematical proposition. $1+1=2$. Bertrand Russell had a nervous breakdown, partly from trying to show that $1+1=2$ was in fact, logically true or reducible to logic. He doesn't think he ever got there in the end. So it's a deceptively simple proposition, but let's stick with it. $1+1=2$ —the number 2. I think there's a strong intuitive sense in which the number 2 is a transcendent object. And I think there's a strong intuitive sense in which the truth, $1+1=2$, is a transcendent truth in the Platonic sense. And I just want you to try to imagine what it might be to say that once upon a time, deep in the mists of time, even before the Big Bang, $1+1\neq 2$, did not come to 2. That once upon a time, the number 2 did not exist, and that once upon a time, the number 2 will cease to exist.
- 3.23** Now, I hope you can, if you can feel the oddness of those claims, then you're starting to understand what it would be for something to be transcendent. We're starting, I think, simply and straightforwardly, and if you can grasp that, then you're beginning to grasp what Plato means by transcendent, by something belonging to the World of Being outside space and time, not involved in the messy World of Becoming and "causation" and "change". It just is.
- 3.24** And by the way, if the number 2 exists, infinitely many things exist. Why? Well, just think about it. How odd would it be if the number 2 existed but the number 3 didn't? And so on and so on and so on. I mean, how odd would it be if the series of natural numbers just ran out at 450 trillion and 2? It would be odd. It would be surprising if the sequence of natural numbers were finite. Why? Because finitude cries out for explanation. The philosopher can always say of something that's finite. Why? Why does

it stop there? How come it might not have existed? What is his explanation? Infinity, for the philosopher is much simpler and cleaner than the finite. So infinitely many transcendent things exist. Plato's heaven is infinitely vaster than our four-dimensional spacetime.

3.25 So we've got a sense, I hope already, of what Plato is after by the transcendent, and why he puts so much emphasis on learning and being formed in mathematics and geometry. Above the lintel, it's alleged, of the gate to the academy into the grove outside Athens, was the Greek sentence, "The person without mathematics"—I think it's an *Ageometrētos*—"The unnumbered person may not enter here. So there's something clean and transcendent about mathematical knowledge for Plato. But it's not the ultimate kind of knowledge. It's a good way of getting out of the world, of Becoming, but it still falls short of the ultimate Form of knowledge, of knowing, which is contemplation, and the ultimate object of contemplation— *tou agathou*—the good. The good is what is ultimate for Plato. He even says at one point in the Republic that, "The Good is beyond Being." For Plato, the Good is the organizing horizon of all reality and the ultimate ambition of any human being. Although in Plato's view, only a very few, a very select few, were capable of the training and the capacity, had the capacity, the cognitive capacity and the discipline to achieve contemplation of the Good.

3.26 The way Plato develops his "theory" is not by theorizing as I said. It's through something quite surprising. It's through pictures—parables. Why do I say that's surprising? It's surprising because pictures and parables are the sorts of things Plato is ordinarily very suspicious about. He's suspicious of the Homeric bards, of the tragedians. He's suspicious of art and poetry. In Book 10 of the Republic, he says they've got to be banned—got to ban the artists and the poets and the musicians. Why? Because he thinks that they're not anchored to truth. And they have a tendency, therefore, to seduce the people away from truth and to mesmerize and enchant them through pleasure. But as I said, I think in the second lecture, Plato never was quite able to put away his youthful aspirations to become the greatest tragedian in Athens. Maybe he wanted to ban all the poets because he thought that the perfect state only had room enough for one poet—him. And he is a brilliant poet. He is a brilliant literary artist, as I've said already in previous lectures.

3.27 Let's start with the first picture. And this is a picture, not even a parable, not even a story. The picture is simply the sun. He says, if we want to understand something about the Good, think about the sun, we must think about the sun. Why? "Well," he says, "the sun is the reason we can see anything at all. It's the source of all visibility. The sun is the source of all life. Without the sun, there would be no existence." Plato says the Good is like that. What we're trying to get to at the highest pinnacle of knowing is something that is comparable to the sun. Obviously, the sun, as a source of visibility and existence, is a source for those two things in the World of Becoming. But he thinks

that the Good is a source for intelligibility and for being in the World of Being. What can we make of this?

- 3.28** Well, suppose we pointed to a candle and somebody said, "Look at that candle. That's an object that illuminates the room. Oh, and look at the sun streaming in through the window. That's an object that illuminates the room as well." I don't know what your reaction would be to somebody who said that. My reaction would be, that's true. But I don't think you've quite understood the difference between the candle and the sun. Candlelight is borrowed light. Sunlight is not. The sun is not borrowing its power to illuminate from anything else. It is the ultimate intrinsic source of all light in virtue of which all other light is possible and without which no light would be possible.
- 3.29** Okay, now, this is what Plato thinks is true of the Good. The Good is not good. It's goodness. It's the reason why anything else is good or can be called good. It's the benchmark against which we can measure whether something is good or not, and the degrees of its goodness. There is, as it were, no borrowed being in the Good, no borrowed goodness. It's the source of all goodness. And I think in that sense we can start to understand that strange phrase that the Goodness is beyond Being. In the sense that everything that exists, everything that has being for Plato has it in virtue of this other thing, this ultimate source or reality.
- 3.30** In the next lecture, we're going to start to look at the way in which Abrahamic monotheism, Christian theology, and Jewish theology and Islamic theology gets very excited about this. And a key question in the history of Platonism after Plato is whether or not you can take one of the O's out of the Good. That's for the next lecture.
- 3.31** Let's stick with the allegory of the sun—the first of these three pictures and parables. This is how we're supposed to understand the Good. The metaphor of vision, of intelligibility, is crucial here. And there are a lot of the Dialogues where the sun plays a kind of, has a walk-on part—think of the *Phaedrus*. There's a moment in the *Phaedrus* Dialogue when Socrates is walking with his friend outside the city— always very significant when he's walking outside the city, he's in the World of Being, not of Becoming, the World of Nature, not of Convention, of the Objective, not the Subjective — and they say, "Gosh, the sun is burning bright, it's burning so much. Let's take shade underneath the Plato tree"—"ypó tó plátanos". And what that means is that the argument is about to reach its most intense point. The Dialectic is about to reach its most intense point. So he's constantly playing with the images of sunlight and the metaphor of the sun. So that's the first way in Book 6 of the *Republic* that he gets us ready and used to this notion of what he means by the Good.
- 3.32** The second picture is the so-called Divided Line. And I want you to imagine with me, if you would, a line that goes vertically down like this, and separates Being and Knowing with the weakest forms of both Being and Knowing at the bottom of the vertical line and the most powerful forms, the most permanent Forms of Being and Knowing at the top. And then a horizontal line across that vertical line that divides the World of

Becoming, below the line, from the World of Being above the line. Okay? At the very bottom of the vertical line, below the horizontal line, on the one hand, we have the World effectively of Sense Experience. And on the side of Knowing the Forms of Knowing the objects of Sense Experience could be at the weakest level—hallucinations, dreams— getting a little stronger—Opinions. So things that might be true, but they're not anchored yet quite. Above Opinions—Beliefs. And then we start to hit the horizontal line. So World of Sense Experience, objects and rocks and objects of scientific inquiry, and we come all the way up and we hit the horizontal line. And at this point we go from the World of Sense Experience to the realm—the topos noitikos—the World of Thought, away from physical vision to cognition, to thought.

3.33 And here on the Being side, just above the horizontal line, we have geometric forms, mathematical objects, and then logical reasoning and mathematical reasoning on the Knowing side. And it goes all the way up, ultimately, to contemplation of the Good at the top. So that's the Divided Line, really, one line down and the horizontal line across. And that, in a single image, is Plato's epistemology on one side, on the right-hand side, and it's his metaphysics or ontology on the left-hand side. Degrees of Being, degrees of Knowing.

3.34 Notice again that this turns our contemporary picture completely upside down. Today, we put the objects of science at the top, and scientific knowledge is the benchmark. It's the most powerful kind. And we put the non-material invisible things that are not the objects of physical vision at the bottom. That's pure speculation. That's kind of abstract and that's spooky. And we can't possibly agree on those kinds of questions in a liberal, plural, democratic society. No way. So it's dangerous if we think otherwise. It's dangerous if we give too much content to this. Now, I'm not making any judgment there. I'm just pointing out to you again this extraordinary contrast between Plato's vision and the contemporary vision.

3.35 Okay, that's the second picture. The third is not a picture, but a parable. Just in a few short paragraphs at the end of Book 6 and the beginning of Book 7 of the Republic—the most famous paragraphs in the history of philosophy—the so-called Myth of the Cave—Allegory of the Cave. There's an irony there that it's often called the Myth of the Cave. Plato is suspicious of mythos. He much prefers logos, but he uses mythos to convey logos. He uses story to convey reason and truth. He understands the power of image, the power of storytelling, the power of investing our inquiry into the nature of ultimate reality with meaning.

3.36 The parable of the Cave is very simple. Imagine Socrates asks his interlocutors, "A group of prisoners huddled in the bottom of a cold, dank, dark cave, chained together, but not being terribly bothered about the conditions and their imprisonment, because they're so mesmerized and hypnotized by the flickering flames, casting images and shadows on the back of the cave." The image of flames is interesting here, remember I said Heraclitus, the pre-Socratic, thought that all reality could be reduced to flux and to fire,

the Heraclitean Fire. And I think the image is suggesting that the World of the Cave, cave light, is the World of Heraclitus, the World of pure Becoming. These hypnotizing flames, the shadows cast by the flames, these were the fires kindled by the poets, by the tragedians, by Netflix, by the world of popular culture, constantly seducing us and distracting us, mesmerizing, hypnotizing, anesthetizing us away from the Beautiful, the True, and the Good.

- 3.37** And then one of the prisoners, for reasons that are not made entirely clear, breaks free of the chains and walks, stumbling up the pathway, up out of the cave light into the sunlight outside, and is blinded by the sun and disoriented. And it takes a while, Socrates says, for this prisoner to adjust his gaze to the world of ultimate reality. There are a few more details to that parable, but that, in essence, is what it is. We don't need to make it more complicated than that. It's an image of Plato's—it captures and distills better than any other image or story— Plato's concept of reality.
- 3.38** One of the influences that Plato is wrestling with is another pre- Socratic, this figure of Parmenides. And Parmenides objected to, or offered a very different view from Heraclitus. He said that, "No, Becoming is an illusion. Really, everything is ultimately, it just is Being. And changes on the surface are just illusions, different ways in which a single undifferentiated Being discloses itself— to on—Being.
- 3.39** Plato's genius and one of the reasons for the impact that he's had on Western philosophy is that he combines in this simple parable those two great conflicting visions of ultimate reality. There's the World of Becoming, the cave light, and the World of Being, the sunlight. And it's not as if the cave is just a kind of fake world, it's just purely illusion. So this is not, as some Indian philosophical schools would insist, or Buddhist philosophical schools would insist, just a pure world of illusion—m aya. But one that does have a degree of reality to it. It's just not ultimate reality. It's proximate reality. It is—in using the word of Bill Nicholson's play about C S. Lewis and the film that emerged shortly after in 1993—"We're in the Shadowlands. We're in the Shadowlands."
- 3.40** So that's part of the power of what Plato is achieving. He's incorporating this idea that things are in a state of change, and yet also the world of ultimate reality is stable, eternal, and timeless. And it's the task of all true philosophers, and certainly all philosophers, as we'll see in the next lecture, who aspire to order and structure the city-state and the nation, and to govern society. It is the task of all of those philosophers to train themselves in contemplating and achieving the Good, of breaking out of the chains, and through Socrates' methods, through the dialectic, through close examination, dialog, philosophical exchange, getting out of the cave light into the sunlight. And that's what qualifies the philosopher to be a ruler. And it's why only philosophers can be, and ought to be, rulers.
- 3.41** So those are the three iconic images and parallels that we get from the Republic. And we can see that this has a real plausibility, even if it cuts against the grain of the various approaches that we saw in the other corner that I canvassed earlier, in the other corner

of the wrestling ring. Because if that picture that Plato presents is true, or even close to true, then empiricism is false because it's a philosophy that's addicted to the shadows on the wall of the cave, mistaking those shadows for ultimate reality that's hooked on the World of Becoming. If this picture is right, constructivism is wrong. Where ultimate reality is discovered outside the cave, not constructed or invented or projected onto the wall of the cave.

- 3.42** And if this story is correct, the masters of suspicion are incorrect. That reason is possible even if it can be erratic, even if it needs to be formed and trained. But reason is not undermined by the motives that generate it, that lie behind it, that it's possible for reason to connect to reality, that we need not be suspicious of every truth claim. If we're to be suspicious of every truth claim simply because of some narrative of suspicion, or because of some accidental feature of the person advancing the argument—sex or skin color or background—then thought stops, dialog stops.
- 3.43** Plato would not have been comfortable with identity politics. All of Platonism is oriented against the claim that somehow your identity confers a special strength on the claims that you advance. That would imply that one could never start an argument with the phrase, "As a person of x, I believe y." For Plato, that suggests, that's the mark of a disordered and confused mind, that truth is not constructed. It's not granted special privileges simply because of contingent physiological characteristics of the person advancing it. There is right, there is wrong, there is truth, and there is falsehood.
- 3.44** Now the question for us is, are there other pathways out of the cave and into the land of the sun than merely Socratic dialectic? Well, that's something that we'll come on to in the next lecture and in the final lecture.
- 3.45** Plato thinks that we can train ourselves on the transcendent through mathematics, through philosophy. But there are other Dialogues where he seems to suggest that there are other ways that we can kind of quicken our pulse for the transcendent. In the Symposium, he talks about the power of beauty to quicken our pulse for the transcendent. In this Symposium, he says, "We see beautiful things, we see a beautiful image. And when we think that image is beautiful, or that that person is beautiful, or that that sunset is beautiful, we're seeing something that lies beyond those things, that those things, as it were, instantiate or exemplify," or, to use the Platonic term, "participated." There is a Form of Beauty, says Plato in the Symposium, and again in Book 5 of the Republic and elsewhere, in fact. And beautiful things are beautiful not in themselves, but because they hook onto exemplify, participate in the Form of Beauty. In the Symposium, he says, "Beauty is not anywhere in another thing, as in an animal, or in earth, or in heaven, or in anything else but itself, by itself, with itself."
- 3.46** Now, if that seems confusing or surprising, we need to just touch very quickly on an ancient problem in the history of philosophy. And that problem is the problem of the Difference between the Universal and the Particular. Some of you are wearing blue shirts. I can say of your particular shirts that they're all blue. But although the shirts are

distinct particulars, distinct in space and time, they seem to be sharing in one thing, a universal color, blueness, being blue, a property. At least that seems the most plausible way of analyzing it. I mean, do you want to say that, "No, blueness is as separate and discrete as the shirts"? That seems odd that there's just Being that blue shirt and Being that blue shirt, and that the use of the word blue in those two sentences should not be implied to mean that there's anything in common between them? Philosophers are profoundly puzzled by this.

3.47 Plato has an answer. There are Forms, there are Universals, objective realities, which different, spatiotemporally separated particular things, objects can participate in and exemplify. And so we can understand the resemblance, and we can make true claims about x—all these x's sharing a single y property, all these shirts Being blue, Being one kind of having one Mode of Being in the World. I don't want to go too far down that rabbit hole, but I just wanted to put that on the table for you, to show that there's real philosophical power and theoretical clarity that the Platonic picture brings to contemporary philosophy. There are problems with it, too, which we don't need to go into, but it's certainly a contender in this ancient debate on what it is and what a Universal might be, and how we make sense of resemblance across Particulars in space and time.

3.48 Are there other ways out of the cave and into the sun? Well, as we see in the next lecture, there are all sorts of ways in addition to the dialectic and to sense of Beauty and aspiration, the sort of quickening of the pulse through Beauty, there is also the Sense of the Sacred, a Sense of the Sacred, Sense of the Sacred. A sense that we find very difficult to make sense of in a post religious world. But it's still there. We still instinctively feel it and sense it and aware of it, and we don't want to simply dismiss it. We don't want to simply say that this is an illusion. There's something profound about it. There's a stirring towards some kind of ultimate meaning, an orientation to capital T Transcendence.

3.49 Typically, in the modern world, we'll be asked to prove that this object or this experience was Sacred. But, of course, the standards of proof that are being asked for and insisted upon are the standards of the cave. Are the standards of scientific inquiry, scientific criteria, merely logical reasoning. The standards of the World of Becoming, and so the Sacred is not provable, obviously, in that way. If it were, it would not be Sacred because it would not be a stirring towards capital T Transcendence. It would be a stirring to a shadow cast by the flickering flames on the wall of the cave. And so, in a sense, that quickly becomes a Dialectic of the Deaf, a Dialog of the Deaf, ships passing in the night.

3.50 You either see it or you don't. You either feel that Sense of the Sacred and of the Transcendent or you don't. You either think that the ceiling of the Sistine Chapel or Beethoven's 4th Piano concerto is a very clever evolutionary, socio-biological development or quirk that one part of the race has developed, or you really do think

that it is somehow stirring something within you that is allowing you to break the chains and walk up out of the pathway into the land of the sun. But there's no way of arbitrating between those two positions. Sometimes philosophy has to stop, and we rely on our intuitions, and we must proceed with them and bring along with us anyone who's willing to share them or at least engage with them.

- 3.51** I'll close with this—a short passage from a sermon delivered by C. S. Lewis, 1898-1963—a fascinating figure who in many ways could be described as a Christian Platonist. And I put this quote in here, just because we'll be looking more at Christian Platonism and indeed other forms of Platonism, as we consider Plato's afterlives in lecture 5. But here's a sermon that he gave at St. Mary's, the university church in Oxford on the high street in June 1941, as the Second World War was reaching its terrible peak. He says this, "The books or the music in which we thought the beauty was located will betray us if we trust to them; it was not in them, it only came through them, and what came through them was longing."—In Plato's sense, eros, love, a yearning for the Truth, a yearning for Beauty—"These things, the beauty, the memory of our own past, are good images of what we really desire"—but they're images illuminated only by the cave light, but pointing the way to the route outside of the cave—"But if they are mistaken for the thing itself, they turn into dumb idols, breaking the hearts of their worshippers. For they are not the thing itself. They are only the scent of a flower we have not found, the echo of a tune we have not heard, news from a country we have never yet visited."
- 3.52** Thanks for listening. Questions— gentleman at the front.
- 3.53** So, postmodernists claim that truth cannot be known as in epistemologically. Dr. Peterson, as well, has mentioned that this postmodern issue is a problem of perception. What would your thoughts be on that?
- 3.54** Yes, I think the puzzle is that, if your only benchmark for what counts as true or as it counts as a justified belief is sense experience, then, as it were, the Truth will always be elusive, or it will always be perspectival because it will always be anchored to the experiencing or perceiving subject. And that experiencing or perceiving subject will bring all sorts of presuppositions that will shape and deform, as it were, or characterize the objects of sense experience, and so we can't ever get beyond that.
- 3.55** And so in some sense that makes sense. So colors are, in quite an obvious way, a function of the way in which we perceive reality. So the color blue doesn't exist as something that inheres in the shirts, that belongs to the shirts. It's simply that the shirts are made of a material which, when light is refracted upon it and hits the back of our retinas, creates the image in the sense of blueness. So, in fact, it's not a great example for a Universal, because Plato thought it's out there objectively. So I think that's the concern. And my understanding of where Dr. Peterson is at, at the moment, is to say that that would condemn you to a kind of perspectival relativism, and that we must be able to say that the perceptual objects are more than merely perceptual, that they transcend our perceptual field, that they do exist. So this is a kind of realism, a

commitment to there being perception-independent objects that will be there, whether or not there are perceivers to grasp them.

3.56 In the last lecture, we were talking about how Sophists control the masses basically through relativism, based on saying—if I'm putting that right—based on saying, "Well, truth doesn't really exist, so we'll just basically mold it to shape our views so we can control as many people" in a sense. And then in this lecture, we were talking about how Nietzsche kind of said the opposite, where actually the masses control powerful based on morals. And I think that we can all see both of those coming into light in our society today. But my question is—and obviously with the refusal of dialogue that also comes into it—but my question is: With Plato's idea of Goodness and that philosophers ought to be the real leaders, how do we know that the philosophers are not themselves, also trapped in this dilemma? Because at the end of the day, we're all still human. We're all still subject to these biases and desires. So because Plato doesn't define Goodness, he just says it's an "essence." How would you solve that dilemma of, like, oh, the philosopher truly did find the sign, for example? How do we know he's not just trapped into another flame?

3.57 Excellent question. You've perfectly distilled a sneak preview of the next lecture, so thank you for that. Because you've correctly seen, very insightfully, what the political ramifications would be of Plato's philosophical project. Because I've already hinted, though I've not unpacked, the point that it's only the philosophers who can be the rulers. And so there's a lot riding on Plato getting the metaphysics right, given how much he's going to insist that society is shaped around that metaphysical framework. But to answer your question, or the question at the end: Is there any answer to the skeptic who simply says, "But what if you're wrong? I don't believe you. You're just saying this because you're that. " And this is a very interesting problem in philosophy more generally. In the end, I said earlier that, sometimes philosophy has to stop and you need to walk away. Now, you want to make sure that you walk away as far down the road as possible.

3.58 But there comes a point, I think, with the skeptic, the true skeptic, where one runs out of things to say. It is possible that the world was made up with the illusion of age five minutes ago—it's possible, at least—what would evidence against that claim look like? Any evidence that we brought against that, "But we were just having coffee an hour ago." Any evidence for that would be, of our memories, would simply be refuted by the skeptics saying, "But of course. It's part of the illusion. The mad scientists with all our brains in a vat, that part of the illusion that we were having coffee an hour ago." Now the question is: What can you do with the skeptic? It will always be possible to test and to probe a belief that seems as real as anything. How can we prove to each other that we are minded beings? Do we put our brains under a microscope and go hunting for our minds and our consciousness? That's not going to help. But the skeptic can always

say, "You can't see it under the microscope. Why should we think it's there? Why should we not suppose this is an illusion?"

- 3.59** One response to this is the response given by the Cambridge philosopher G. E. Moore in his *Defense of Common Sense*, one of the shortest arguments in the history of philosophy. 1st premise—here is my hand. 2nd premise—here is my other hand. Conclusion— the world exists.
- 3.60** Now, you may not think that's a very good argument. Moore's point was not to prove that the world actually exists. Moore's point was to try to convince the skeptic, or to say to the non-skeptical world, that the premises of any skeptical argument, concluding that these are not, in fact, my hands, will never be strong enough to displace my intuitions, my prephilosophical intuitions, that these are indeed my hands. So don't bother with the skeptical arguments, and I don't need to show where they go wrong. Why start there?
- 3.61** The reason we do start there is probably a legacy of figures like Descartes, Cartesian skepticism. Descartes says, "Well, how can I be sure of anything? Well, the way I can work out what I can be sure of is to be suspicious of everything, be skeptical of everything, and maybe I can find something that I can't be skeptical about. And he thought that that was the fact that I'm thinking, can I be skeptical of that. And then can I get my way back out of my skeptical hole now?" Now, it turned out the way out of the skeptical hole was not terribly convincing, at least not more convincing than the way down into the skeptical hole.
- 3.62** So this is slightly speculative, but that sort of move left Western philosophy with the kind of the specters of skepticism. And perhaps the only answer is to say, "These are my hands, and I don't care what you're trying to tell me about this babble of brains in a vat."
- 3.63** I'm curious if you, as an educator, feel that we have properly implemented Platonic dialogue into our systems of education.
- 3.64** Yes.
- 3.65** If not, then how can we do so in an environment where hierarchy is so important and dialogue is subsequent to that?
- 3.66** Yeah, that's a great question. So it's not intrinsic to dialogue that there be, as it were, kind of flat plane of all the conversation partners. And in none of the Dialogues, for example, does—I mean, in most all the Dialogues—you have this almost comic asymmetry and caliber and competence between Socrates and his interlocutors. And some of the early Dialogues are just very funny, because there are people who are just plainly not cut out for philosophy, like Lache's general, for example, or somebody like Cephalus in the *Republic*, who just, they're not able to do it. And yet progress is still

made, if for no other reason that this poor guy who is supposed to be the expert on courage, clearly is exposed as not having any clue. And so the hierarchy there is okay.

3.67 But to get to the early part of your first part of your question, I think there needs to be as much dialogue within systems of education as is possible and is manageable within vast, complex educational institutions. Typically, the form of teaching is very often rather Sophistic, like this. Well, like the earlier part, we're engaging now in dialogue. At my own university in Cambridge and also in Oxford, we have the so-called tutorial system, where undergraduates meet with a professor generally once or twice a week, on-on-one or two- on-one. That's been going since, I think, the early 19th century. And I think that there's a strong case to be made that that's what gives those two universities, or one's pedagogical formation at those universities something different and distinctive and enormously beneficial, in fact. And actually part of the reason for the institutional emphasis in Oxford and Cambridge on the dialogic tutorial system came from Benjamin Jowett, who was a very important figure in 19th century Oxford. He was the Master of Balliol College, Vice Chancellor of the University, and the translator of all of Plato's Dialogues.

3.68 If you go onto Amazon and look up Plato's Dialogues, his is the translation to get for \$1, but it's a very good translation. And so he took the Socratic mode of Socratic inquiry and dialogue and Platonic dialogue very seriously. And that's one of the reasons that's one of his legacies, has been that stress on the pedagogical mode of engagement, being conversation and dialogue.

3.69 What was that again?

3.70 Benjamin Jowett, JOWETT. The kind of rhyme goes, "My name is Benjamin Jowett, I am Master of this college. There's no knowledge, but I know it."

Lecture 4: Plato on Politics

At a glance — This lecture examines Plato on politics, starting from the Greek polis and the Republic's account of justice, the philosopher-ruler, and the ideal city, alongside the tensions and later worries about its authoritarian implications.

- 4.1 So lecture 4—Plato on politics. What do we mean by the word politics? Very difficult to pin down a definition. But I'll simply note that its origins etymologically are Greek and emerge from the concept, the word, the name polis, which doesn't quite mean city, something more like city-state. Something like maybe Singapore or Hong Kong, a metropolitan city-state that is contained, autonomous and tightly organized. Plato's greatest Dialogue is not actually called the Republic. It was called "Politeia", Politeia, which you might roughly translate as "constitution", the polis constitution. Republic, "res publica" is a Latin term that emerges much later. Cicero writes "De Re Publica", "on the public", on matters of public concern.
- 4.2 So politics is the business of the polis, of organizing it, of structuring it, of governing it. And Athens as a polis, by the time Plato starts work on the Republic, probably in the 390s, had disintegrated many times over, in the second half of the 5th century BC. It had, after a successful victory against the forces—the combined forces of Persia, the Battle of Marathon in 490, the Battle of Salamis in 480, Thermopylae in 479—it had begun to acquire a kind of imperialistic posture towards other Greek city-states.
- 4.3 It attempted to, first of all, benevolently set up a league, the so-called Delian League, as a kind of protective mechanism against another attempt from Persia to invade Greece. But very quickly, over the 450s, 440s, 430s,— you can see this in the epigraphy on the statues, the stones of the time— there was a shift from Athens conceiving itself as an ally, to thinking of itself as an imperial power. The language would move from the Delian League, the Athens and her allies, to simply the Athenians.
- 4.4 There was plague in the 420s, endless battles, and devastating conflicts with Sparta, the great militaristic state just across on the Peloponnese, just across from Attica, mainland Attica. There was, when Plato was, in his early teenage years, a catastrophic expedition to conquer Sicily in 415 BC, which ended in total disaster and a fatal weakening of Athens as a geopolitical and military power. And the democracy that was driving all of this began to disintegrate and degenerate into an oligarchy, the 30 tyrants.
- 4.5 And that in turn collapsed in the face of renewed assault from radical democrats. And it's in this mix that the decision is taken to put Socrates on trial and to demand his execution in 399. So that's the sort of background, the context, the immediate historical context for the Republic. And these experiences that the young Plato would have had growing up in his teenage years—into his early 20s, is probably mid-20s when Socrates is put on trial— had an extraordinary impact, a lasting impact, on his politics, on his understanding of how the polis should be constructed in a way that would make

it invulnerable and immune to these sorts of crises. So there's a negative motivation for the Republic, for Plato's political vision.

- 4.6 And we get this in the very opening to the Republic in Book 1, with the claim in the figure of Thrasymachus that might is right, there is no justice. The polis does not need to be anchored to the Good or oriented to the Transcendent in order to flourish.
- 4.7 And, of course, Plato suspected that a lot of this chaos in the final decades of the 5th century emerged not just from democracy, but from what democracy was vulnerable to, namely, the rhetoric of Athens's best and brightest, formed by the sophists, formed in a way that they're tracking not truth, but advancement, self-interest, and power.
- 4.8 One of the fascinating features of the Republic is the insistence early on by Socrates that we can't really answer the animating question of the Republic—*tí estí dikaiosýni*—what is justice? Because we can't really understand what it is to be a person. Early on, he insists, and there's agreement that justice must benefit the person who possesses it. It must enhance its possessor in some way. And Socrates then says, "Well, but we can't even work out what's beneficial to a person possessing something if we don't know what a person is. What are we?"
- 4.9 Socrates in the Republic takes it for granted that we are souls. We are embodied souls. And we are souls that are, to varying degrees, ordered. Some souls are disordered, some are ordered. And the great picture that he advances to help us think about what it is to be a soul is in the myth of the charioteer. In a different Dialogue, the Phaedrus. And this picture has the charioteer driving a chariot with two horses, a white horse and a black horse. The white horse is spirited, driven by a kind of courage—a *thumos* in the Greek. And the black horse is driven by appetite and sensual pleasure, a desire for sensual pleasure. And the charioteer's task is to keep these two horses in check.
- 4.10 The charioteer represents the rational "*psyché*", the rational seat of the soul—reason. The white horse represents *thumos* means really chest, the sort of the courage, the spiritedness, the spirited part of our natures. And the black horse represents the appetitive part of our natures. So it's a three-tiered picture of the human person. And this picture persists right into the Republic. And Plato says, "Well, we've got to work out this question of 'What is justice?' And we've got to work it out in terms of how does it benefit its possessor?" But Socrates says, "This is just too difficult. We can't do this. It would be much easier for us, instead, to look rather than at what a well-ordered soul might be, to consider what a well-ordered city might be."
- 4.11 And this toggling between soul and city is one of the most fascinating features of Plato's thought. He thinks that there's a close complicity between the individual and the collective. That each of the three parts of the soul represent character types within any political community. And he grades them without apology in a hierarchy, a normative hierarchy, with the Gold-Souled Citizens at the top—representing the character type of a soul that is Ordered by, with the charioteer, as it were, in total

command— the Silver-Souled Citizenry—that part of a city-state, those citizens in a political community that are distinguished by their spiritedness, we might think, army officers, policemen, firemen—and finally, the Bronze-Souled Citizens—the overwhelming majority, Plato thinks, in any community, the farmers, the serfs, those working the land, driven, Plato thinks, merely by Appetite, sensual pleasures and immediate bodily satisfactions, desires for food and drink and sex, and that that and are not properly Ordered.

4.12 And so Plato insists that the psychological health and political health depend upon the wise part of the soul or the city being able to govern the other two without being overthrown or undermined in any way. And so the ideal ordered soul exhibits all of the four cardinal virtues. The four cardinal virtues, from the Latin *cardo*, meaning the hinge, the sort of four hinges—wisdom, courage, temperance, slightly old-fashioned word, we might say, moderation, self-control, and justice—wisdom, courage, moderation, and justice.

4.13 The Ordered Soul is Wise, has Wisdom, the Virtue of Wisdom, because he grasps objective Reality. He's made his way up out of the cave. He's got wisdom. He's got courage, inasmuch as he's not going to let fear or appetite—the fear from the spirited part of the soul, or appetite from the appetitive, sensual part of the soul—overthrow him or distract him from doing the right thing, whatever the cost. So there's courage there for the Well-Ordered Soul. Moderate, temperate in that he's not going to be won over by his sensual side. It's going to be control there and will indulge them only when it's fitting and only in the proper context, the third cardinal Virtue. And finally, Just. The Well-Ordered Soul will be a Just Soul, because the Soul will be properly proportioned, will be properly Ordered. Reason, Spirit, and Appetite will all be playing their proper role and function within this ensouled hierarchy.

4.14 The unhealthy Soul, the Disordered Soul, will, as it were, be the reverse of that, will have all of those three parts out of proportion. And rebelling an intention against all, against the other, against each other. And Plato, as I said, thinks that society represents or has within it those three layers. Reason at the top, Spirit, and then Appetite at the bottom. Now, I should say the people at the bottom, the Bronze-Souled Citizens, are not completely incapable. They have a proper place and a proper contribution to make in society. But because they haven't got reason, or reason at least hasn't got control over them, and they haven't got the spiritedness, they tend not to pursue wisdom and honor just for their own sakes. But they're essential because they make up, in effect, the overwhelming majority. And they are the producers, they're the productive class—the farmers, the tradesmen, and so on, the workmen, the factory workers, and so on.

4.15 The next level in society would be the spirited, those driven by Thumos. And as I said, these might be the local police force, those in charge of the military. They will be much smaller. But again, as with the other rank, the lowest rank in society, they will have a crucial place. The city can't function properly without them. And so this group are

directed mainly to honor, justice, courage, but they will lack the wisdom of the Gold-Souled Citizens, which is the smallest class of all— the ruling class, the Philosopher Rulers. Often the phrase Philosopher Kings is used, but in fact, one striking feature of the Republic and his later work, the Laws, is that Plato insists that women have just as much capacity and caliber and competence to be Philosopher Rulers as men. Very surprising in the context of Greek culture, and indeed, culture around the Mediterranean in that period for then and many centuries thereafter. But Plato is absolutely insistent that there can be as many Philosopher Queens as Philosopher Kings.

- 4.16** And so this is the picture that gradually develops over the course of Books 2, Books 3, Book 2, 3, and 4 of the Republic. As Socrates in these long speeches, without really letting anyone get a word in edgeways—not much of a dialog for long stretches—he sketches out the Calipolis, beautiful city, his vision for the perfectly ordered city that is maximally conducive to sustaining and generating well ordered souls. And it's an ancient hermeneutical, interpretative challenge to work out what Plato thought by utopia, did he think that utopia meant, this is a perfect city that can be realized? Or did he think that utopia is simply, as it were, an idealized blueprint—a roadmap that could never quite be, a blueprint that could never quite be attained, but could be used as something to aim at, to aspire towards, and, as it were, as a kind of standard against which to measure the success of a political community's development?
- 4.17** We'll see later on in the Laws—possibly the last Dialogue and the longest Dialogue that Plato ever wrote—that he is much more realistic and a little bit more tyrannical in how he thinks a city should be organized. And there's a kind of pragmatism in the Laws and an idealism in the Republic that would suggest that the Laws are as a prescription for something that could be achieved. And the Republic was, as it were, an idealized blueprint that should be aspired to, but could never, in fact, be attained or implemented.
- 4.18** Plato then, in Book 8 and Book 9—after those high points that we discussed in the previous lecture, Book 6 and Book 7, which contains the philosophy and the metaphysics, the kind of the Mount Everest of Plato's Dialogues, and the highest peak of the Republic—in Books 8 and 9, he starts to look at what happens when disorder enters into the soul, or disorder enters into the city. So those high points, Book 6 and Book 7, are really a very long answer to the question, "Well, how do we train up and identify and train the philosopher rulers? What do they have to go through?" And really, Book 6 and Book 7 is the answer is in Book 6 and 7, because the answer is the philosopher rulers of those who've understood that the sun is like the Good, who've understood the ordering of reality, who've understood what it is to come to contemplate the Good, and who've understood how to break the chains and lead the way up out of the cave into the sunlight, and then to come back down, and, as it were,

reorder and reorient the prisoners to turn their faces away from the back wall of the cave and towards the sun.

- 4.19 And so education for Plato, I note in passing, is not just conveying information. It's about conversion, in the sense, in the Latin sense, of *converto*, of to turn—turning the gaze of the prisoners, away from the wall of the cave, up to the sun outside.
- 4.20 And so we can see that the perfect city, the well-ordered city, the *calipolis*, for Plato, is, in effect, an aristocracy. *Aristos*, *aristoi*—the best men, *kratos*—power—*aristoi kratos* power is exercised by the best. And for Plato, best did not mean most noble, or with the finest pedigree, or having a peerage or a knighthood in the UK context, or being part of some great dynastic family or presidential family in the US context. But optimality was indexed to philosophical capacity, capacity to contemplate and understand and grasp the Good.
- 4.21 And incidentally, the kind of life that Plato sketches out and insists upon for the philosopher rulers is not a particularly pleasant one. It's a very abstemious, ascetic form of life—no families, no friends, sleeping in dormitories, living very, very simple, frugal lives, completely given over and dedicated to the governance of the state, completely indifferent to sensual pleasure, and totally committed to the contemplative philosophical life. So it's not the kind of aristocracy we might be familiar with.
- 4.22 Now, Plato thinks that the aristocracy can degenerate. And he gives this fascinating and rather terrifying account of how political degeneration happens, how a well ordered community and state can disintegrate over the time based on the various character types that he's identified using the model of the three part soul— reason, spirit and appetite. He thinks that what often happens is that an aristocracy starts to turn towards timocracy, timocracy, from the Greek "*tîmê*", meaning honor. It's an "*time kratos*," it's honor power—power derived from seeking honor, having honor, something actually closer to what we might think of as an aristocracy. And this is where the spirited part, the spirited citizens, start to assert themselves against the gold-plated reasoning citizens, the philosopher rulers.
- 4.23 And a timocracy is not a terrible state. The rulers are seeking honor. They're not capable of the kind of wisdom that is needed. But nevertheless, it's a broadly functioning state. But the direction of travel is concerning because soon, Plato claims, the quest for honor becomes a merely public, performative quest. And what starts to seep in because of the absence of wisdom in private, is a desire for money and wealth, power through financial assets, financial muscle.
- 4.24 And Plato then says so, tensions start to erupt between the ruling class, the oligarchy. The timocracy becomes an oligarchy—a rule by the "*oligoi*"— the few, "*arche*"—rule, *oligarchos*, *oligarchía*. And again, this is not a completely dysfunctional state. But what happens now when money, not honor, is the ultimate end of the rulers, is that you start to see, says Plato, enormous tensions between rich and poor. The rich in

particular, he says, start to give credit and permit loans. Maybe, he might say today, print money through quantitative easing and modern monetary theory. Money does grow on trees, actually. We just need to cut enough of them down and ship them off to the fed.

4.25 And he says the oligarchs try, then, to indulge the appetites of the young, the frivolity of the young, the immorality of the young, and exploit them to create debt. The young are corrupted. They become lazy and immoderate and completely incapable of being the future citizens that the flourishing city-state needs, or a city-state needs to flourish. Self-discipline and the lust for money are completely incompatible, Plato insists. This is why in the ideal state, the ideal aristocracy, the philosopher rulers don't have any money. There are no private possessions, there is no private property. You can see why the left might love that, or an extreme left might love that. Plato is both a communist and a fascist, right?

4.26 There are no elections in this perfect city-state, but nor is there any private property. There are clear, objective hierarchies. None of this egalitarianism, none of this equality or workers of the world unite. The workers are right at the bottom. They're not getting out of that. And the philosopher rulers are right at the top, the elite are right at the top. So you can see why both sides and up on the contemporary, post-1789 political spectrum of left and right, both love him and hate him.

4.27 So back to the oligarchy—remember—so we've got the aristocracy, degenerates into an oligarchy —I'm sorry—a timocracy quest for honor, which then metastasizes into a quest for just merely public honor, but a desire for private wealth, the oligarchy. And at this point, as the young are extended, are given more debt, and as their passions are indulged more and more, Plato's picture uses an insect metaphor. He says these drones start to emerge, buzzing everywhere, seeking nothing but sex and a varied and luxurious diet. And this is all they're interested in. And so what's happening now is just as with the timocracy and the oligarchy, the spirited part of the soul, of the soul city has displaced the rational part. Now, as it were, the black horse, the appetitive, sensual part of the soul, starts to displace the spirited part. And what begins to emerge is democracy— the rule of the drones.

4.28 Now again, to start with, Plato does not think that a democratic society is in and of itself a dysfunctional society. It can work, it can function, but pretty soon it's going to degenerate. It's not going to last like that. The dynamics internal to democracy have condemned it to, eventually, he says a state of tyranny.

4.29 Why? Well, Plato says, probably correctly, because democracy prizes freedom above everything else. Freedom is the ultimate currency of a democracy. Would seem to make sense. Freedom, democrat, we talk about "liberal democracies", don't we? We use that as a phrase today. The two go together. What it is to be a democracy is to be liberal, is to prize *libertas*—freedom. Not in itself a bad thing, in Plato's view, but a bad thing, he thinks, when it becomes supreme, the supreme value, freedom above all.

- 4.30 Well, why? Because if freedom is the ultimate value, then that includes freedom from everything, including the sources of order and stability and meaning in a society. Laws for the person addicted to raw freedom, says Plato, become an impediment, an obstacle, something we've got to liberate ourselves from. He thinks that lawlessness, anarchy, is a feature of democracy, a feature of liberalism, not a bug, so to speak. Freedom is what liberal democracies do. And liberal democracies, in Plato's view, or freedom-loving democracies, in Plato's view, will always be looking for the next thing to free its citizens from.
- 4.31 Whether the constraint is a good constraint or a bad constraint for the freedom lover or the freedom addict, thinks Plato, all constraints are bad, even the limits and the constraints that enable social flourishing. This is his charge.
- 4.32 Another feature of democracy, says Plato, is an obsession with equality, again, not unreasonable, and has applicability today. But it's equality understood for Plato as sameness. That's a common confusion today, we might think. We tend to think for person A to be equal to person B, is for person A to be the same as person B. And so that might lead to the thought, for example, that for women to be equal to men is for women to be the same as men, doing the same things. Equality as sameness.
- 4.33 The thought that you can have, that person A can have the same value as person B, but be different and distinct persons, men or women or American or British or whatever, is not a thought that this kind of egalitarian contemplates. To be equal is to be the same. And homogeneity is the mark of a maximally egalitarian society.
- 4.34 And the idea that there are layers to society and that there's a distribution of talent and skills and competencies across any sufficiently large sample of human beings is anathema, can't be contemplated. Those differences should be structured in a way that benefits all, must be rejected. This, for Plato, is the error of democratic thinking.
- 4.35 He's also very suspicious of the democrats' love of privacy and of the private realm. Everyone is equal, and therefore no one has a right to say of another citizen that this is for the public, this is to be shared by all. No one has that power. There's no common view of what's good for society, because to assert a common view over others is to undermine the insistence that there's complete equality across all opinion-havers, all havers- of-opinions about what's best for society. And so there's got to be complete neutrality there. This is not a million miles, actually, from the most influential work of political philosophy in the last 50 years.
- 4.36 John Rawls, great American philosopher—the greatest American philosopher, arguably, of the 20th century—publishes a Theory of Justice, 1971. And it's a very long book. I'll save you the trouble of reading it by explaining the brilliant thought experiment that he invites us to undertake at the beginning of that book. He says, in order to create a maximally just society, we don't want to go down Plato's route. But what we should do is put ourselves behind a veil of ignorance, a curtain of ignorance, where the ignorance

relates to not knowing anything about where you're going to end up in this society. You know nothing. You could be at the bottom, you could be at the top. How would you design your perfect society from behind that veil of ignorance?

- 4.37 It's a brilliant idea. Like Plato, it's an experiment. It's a thought, it's an imaginative experiment. And Rawls says there may be certain inequalities in that idealized society that you end up generating from behind the curtain, but they will be tolerable inequalities. They're the kind of inequalities you could tolerate if you're at the bottom and provided it promoted the overall flourishing of society.
- 4.38 But, Rawls insisted, we must, behind the curtain, bracket all your fundamental commitments about ultimate reality, whether you're a Platonist, whether you're a Stoic or a Christian or a Jew or an Eliatic or a Sophist, you must park all of those views because they will simply get in the way and they will not be conducive to social flourishing. Therefore we need, he insists, a completely neutral public square where all comprehensive philosophical doctrines are suspended. It's hard to imagine a picture more divergent from Plato's, where it's the philosophers, it's those who've got the most fully worked out philosophical commitments, who are in charge of designing the whole thing. Where the whole point is to pierce through the veil of ignorance, not to imagine and put oneself behind one.
- 4.39 So we've seen this degeneration, from the aristocracy down to timocracy to oligarchy to democracy, and to this sense that democracy dissolves any common view of flourishing, any common sense of what our fundamental flourishing might look like, because that would destabilize the equal plane. It would bring in coercion in the modern Rawlsian view. And Plato sees this too. He predicts it. He sees that this problem's going to arise, that if you're going to insist on a radical egalitarianism, you have to insist that all views are equal. And so better to insist that you don't express any views at all.
- 4.40 Plato doesn't think that the cycle or the sort of degeneration of the city-state ends there. He thinks that once democracy has dissolved into an ochlocracy— "ochlos" means a mob or a crowd, a rule of a mob, a city that is governed by a completely irrational majority —that that city state becomes ripe for the emergence of a flatterer—a charismatic leader desperate to take over. A tyrannos—a tyrant, a dictator.
- 4.41 And on this view, the tyrant aims not to educate the people, not to find the future philosopher rulers, but to flatter them and to indulge their appetites. The tyrants are gradually, after making all of the promises that he can make, and indulging all the passions of the mob that he can, gradually assumes power, becomes obsessed with power, power completely divorced and unmoored from any sense of the Good and the Right and the True. And then the tyrant himself becomes a slave to his own appetites, his own sensual pleasures, and so on. And all that the tyrant can do to keep hold of power is to encourage conflict within society—conflict and division. Only through

conflict and division can the tyrant's grip on power be secure. Only then can he weaken and reduce any political threat to his total control.

4.42 So that's the picture of Plato's politics as it emerges from the Republic. But by way of a little coda, I should say something about the Laws—his longest Dialogue, 12 Books—and in which he sets out his vision for a city-state in Crete called Magnesia. And as I said it's a much more pragmatic, realistic, but also tyrannical picture than what emerges from the Republic. But there are some interesting features that we should draw our attention to. I should draw our attention to. And it's worth pointing out that in the intervening period, Plato had undertaken disastrous attempts to educate a ruler in Sicily, Dion, the nephew of Dionysius of Syracuse, who was the tyrant. The word tyrant in ancient Greece being a broadly acceptable form of government, meaning simply one man at the top, something like a monarchy. And Dion was willing to learn and was an impressive young man. But all of those attempts to implement a practical vision, the sorts of vision that he was hoping for and dreaming of in the Republic, ended in complete disaster and failure.

4.43 And so the Plato of the Laws is a more chastened figure, a more chastened, humble philosopher, perhaps, and disgruntled philosopher than the Plato of the Republic. And his dream for Magnesia in the Laws is really of a city-state that is completely fossilized, that doesn't try to entertain any new-fangled ideas, that doesn't grow. When the population grows larger than it should, then that excess part of the population must go off and start a new city-state.

4.44 The Laws puts enormous emphasis on education, as does the Republic, on gymnastics and physical exercise, on music, on literature, provided it's sufficiently censored to ensure proper formation of citizens in virtue and good character. And an emphasis on universities, as it were, academy equivalents, higher education, but no sophists. Plenty of music, plenty of astronomy. Music and astronomy being closely connected, of course, to number and to mathematics.

4.45 You might have heard of the medieval quadrivium, which was the second part of a university program in the Middle Ages. You start with the trivium, grammar, rhetoric, and logic, and you move on to the quadrivium, music, astronomy, geometry, and algebra, all four studies that involve number in some way, whether it's number in space, number in motion, number in motion and space, and so on, and time.

4.46 The Laws also stresses—and this is a very interesting development—the importance of religion. Magnesia is, in effect, a theocracy. Why? Because it seems as if Plato comes to understand the power of, the unifying power of, civic religion, at least comes to insist on it. And in the greatest Book of the Laws, Book 10, he sees theology as the unifying discipline, what gathers all of the other disciplines together. And he develops some fascinating criticisms of Ionian atheism, the reductionism of the Ionian philosophers, of Thales, Anaximenes, and Anaximander, and so on.

- 4.47 Actually, in Book 10 of the Laws, there's a version of the cosmological argument for God's existence, one of that large family of arguments for God's existence that starts from some contingent feature of the world and insists that the ultimate explanation for whatever stands at the end of that chain of causes or reasons must be God if we're to avoid an infinite regress of causes or reasons.
- 4.48 Plato wants this argument to work and is insisting upon religion because he thinks that its opposite, atheism, disenchants the world. It rids the world of mystery and magic and value and order. Plato insists in the Laws that it's Logos and Reason and Order that informs Reality, the Universe, and must therefore structure the city-state or be acknowledged by any city-state if it's going to flourish as a state.
- 4.49 So we see this strange notion, state religion is essential in the Laws. This is very different from what we find in the Republic. Now, it may be that Plato had something like the view of religion that Edward Gibbon developed, which Gibbon's line on religion is that, "For the workers, religions were all true. For the intellectuals, they were all false, all equally false. And for the rulers, all religions were equally useful." And it may be that Plato started to take this view that religions have—civic popular religion had a kind of a utility and a power to help organize the masses and to at least provide clues that there is a deeper Logos beyond.
- 4.50 So the idea is that Mythos, Mythoi, Mythology does contain within it fragments of the Logos. And that therefore stories, Mythoi could be anchored in an underlying Truth, in an underlying Reality. This has been a theme of many of Dr. Peterson's recent lectures.
- 4.51 His approach, or most of the time, his approach is the Jungian one that sees, as I mentioned in a previous lecture, Mythoi, Myths, distinct cultural expressions of particular narratives or accounts of meaning, or maps of meaning, as being grounded in an underlying archetype that exists within the human psyche. So the Jungian claim is ultimately— can you see how there are sort of Platonic fingerprints on that picture? Right? We've got the same kind of structure. The idea is there's the Logos, the Mythos, there's the Form and the particular expression of Reality, the universal Form and the particular Reality, the Form outside the cave in the sunlight, and its particular instantiation, containing not all of the sun, but kind of something like the sun in the cave light.
- 4.52 The difference, of course, with Jung is that the archetype resides in the psyche. So that, in principle, once all human beings, once all archetype-bearing beings disappear and die, there cease to be any Logoi, there cease to be any archetypes. Now, it would be clear from the previous lecture that that's not a Platonic picture. It's not a full Platonic picture, but Plato, of course, the Forms, the archetypes, the Platonic archetypes, are objective and real. They are what they are. Like the number 2. They are not going to be bothered by such trivial developments as the Big Bang or the Big Crunch. They are what they are. And for Plato, we can participate in these archetypes. We can exemplify and instantiate them in our stories and in our maps of meaning, but we don't carry them

within us and they don't exist wholly within us. We hook onto them, we don't possess them fully.

- 4.53 And the consequence of that is that ultimate meaning and ultimate alignment with Justice and Goodness and Beauty is much stronger on the Platonic picture. It's not vulnerable to the risk that would suddenly archetype-bearers will just disappear. Beauty is what it is, regardless of there being of evolution, accidentally throwing up human beings who could appreciate Beauty or who could appreciate Truth or Justice. Jung does depend on that. So the Jungian analysis is, as it were, an exercise in anthropology. It's a very sophisticated study of human beings, but it's agnostic or even skeptical that what's going on within human beings when they're hunting for meaning or moved by beauty or motivated to do good, that they are somehow participating in or yearning or connecting to an ultimate reality beyond.
- 4.54 In the modern era. Plato's political vision, as I hinted at earlier, has enraged everyone, no matter where they stand on the political spectrum. The most famous example, perhaps, is Karl Popper, who writes in 1945— a very famous and influential book—The Open Society and Its Enemies, Volume 1—Plato. Volume 2, incidentally, is Hegel and Marx.
- 4.55 And so he thinks that the argument is that Plato is pushing not for an open society, not for liberal democracy, the liberal democracies that they were trying so desperately to create in the wreckage of the Second World War, but a closed society, a society that is kind of proto-fascist, that has views about the Right and the Good and about how those who hold those views should be at the top— to go back to the question that came up at the end of the last lecture—and skeptics don't have a place within the ruling class. And this, for Popper, is the closed society. And it's society that is closed to discovery, closed to development and progress, that are hierarchical, that don't accept dissent, that insist that the essences that they found, the attunement to the good that they've developed in their citizen, their philosophy, Philosopher Rulers, is correct.
- 4.56 Um, that's been a very influential view. And yet there have been other philosophers who have seen a lot more in Plato that is beneficial for understanding our current political predicaments. Critics of communism in the heyday of the Cold War that succeeded the Second World War noted that Plato's critique of a radical egalitarianism, a completely flat society, completely formless society, would bring in its wake, ultimately, a kind of tyranny, as it so happened very quickly, a form of tyranny, as George Orwell and others imagined so brilliantly and predicted so brilliantly. And so, once again, we come back to this conclusion that Plato is infinitely plastic, incredibly difficult to pin down, always illuminating whatever perspective one is approaching a problem from, whether it's a political problem or a philosophical one.
- 4.57 Thanks for listening. Questions? Yes.

- 4.58 You mentioned Plato enraging everyone—made me think of social media in today's current climate. If Plato was around today, what do you think his opinion of social media, censorship, and cancel culture, and that whole situation going on right now—what do you think he would think of that?
- 4.59 I think he would ban social media in all its forms for everyone except the Philosopher Rulers. No question. I think that he would analyze social media as being a catalyst for the steps in the degeneration from oligarchy, well, from timarchy to oligarchy and oligarchy to democracy, and certainly most of all to ochlocracy. And then probably analyze it too, as being the perfect tool for the tyrant who wants to both flatter the mob and also sow division within it. Yeah.
- 4.60 So in our modern society, that seems to confuse wealth with wisdom and maybe even more importantly, with self-worth, how would Plato have seen the difference between the two, or what would have been the building blocks he would have used to value self-worth over wealth?
- 4.61 Great question. I think the starting point of Plato's diagnosis of the confusion of wealth and wisdom, or wealth and self-worth is to insist that that confusion is one that comes from a primarily materialistic outlook, and I mean materialistic in the two senses, both philosophical materialism—namely that all there is is matter, because there's just matter nothing really matters, and you certainly don't matter—and the kind of materialism that we think of in terms of consumerism, just being hooked on stuff, what's going to make me happy is more stuff.
- 4.62 Plato would, I think, diagnose that kind of confusion and that disease and psychological suffering that emerges from that as being, as flowing from basically a philosophical error, just mistakes, a failure to align oneself to the way the world really is. If you're a Philosopher Ruler who is successfully and regularly contemplating the Good—man must be non-material, because it's the World of Being, not Becoming, not vulnerable to the ravages of space and time and so on—then you just are attuned to ultimate Reality, to the fact that ultimate Reality is not material and that there's therefore, nothing that material wealth could rival. There's nothing it could do to make you, as it were, maximally happy, which for Plato is being maximally attuned to the Good.
- 4.63 Thank you.

Lecture 5: Plato's Afterlives

At a glance — Orr traces Plato's afterlives: how Platonism was received, transformed, and transmitted through late antiquity, Neoplatonism, and the Christian tradition, keeping Whitehead's 'footnotes to Plato' in view.

- 5.1** Welcome, everyone, to the penultimate lecture in this series, Lecture 5— Plato's Afterlives. And we're going to go back to that thought at the very beginning of the series from Alfred North Whitehead, that the safest general characterization of European philosophy is that it consists in a series of footnotes to Plato. Today we're going to be looking at some of those footnotes. They're very long footnotes, and they're sometimes very critical footnotes.
- 5.2** The first great figure we have to consider in Plato's wake was his finest student, Aristotle—A ristotle of Stagira, from Macedonia, up in the north. Not an Athenian, but one of the only figures in ancient philosophy who we could plausibly put alongside Plato in terms of the scope of his influence and his impact and his brilliance and genius. The textbooks will tell you that Aristotle rejected most of Plato's teachings. I'm going to suggest a different way of thinking about Aristotle. I think we should think of Aristotle as paying his teacher the homage of critique. But I think if we look carefully, we'll see just how much he absorbed and digested from his teacher.
- 5.3** So, very quickly, what was Aristotle's outlook? What was his reaction to Plato? Well, he was in the academy. After Plato died, he left the academy, set up his own school, his own university, the lyceum in "the Lykeion", the Wolf Grove, moving away from the olive grove to the Wolf grove. And Aristotle founded a whole range of different disciplines, avenues of human inquiry that simply befuddles the mind, simply staggering. We have in Aristotle the first person to set out a treatise on metaphysics, a treatise on the soul, a treatise on physics, on animals, on the weather. He was an astonishingly prolific figure and an astonishingly fertile mind, and would have, as I said, an enormous impact on European thought. Indeed, right up until the 15th century, when Plato's Dialogues begin to be rediscovered and translated into Latin, it was Aristotle who was known simply as "Philosophos"—the Philosopher, by one of his greatest interpreters, Thomas Aquinas.
- 5.4** As I said, it's sometimes said that Aristotle rejected Plato's ideas and his central animating idea, the so called Theory of Forms. But in fact, there are Forms everywhere as far as Aristotle's concerned. The difference is that he reconnects them. He brings them down from Plato's heaven and locates them, inscribes them into natural organisms, into all things. He sees essences everywhere and essences contained in objects. They're not participating or hooking onto Forms up there floating outside the cave in Plato's heaven. These Forms are essences, ways things are—metaphysical profiles, if you like. He would say that it is an essential property, it's part of our essence as a human being to have 32 teeth. It's very attentive to these sorts of physical details.

That doesn't mean when you lose a tooth as a human being, you cease to be a human being. It's simply that there is a fixed, normal, normative way for a human being to be. And it's not, as it were, a profile that is simply constructed. It's fixed. The essences fix what it is to be a particular thing.

- 5.5** Aristotle doesn't reject Plato's idea of the Soul or commitment to our ensoulment. In fact, he sees Soul everywhere, in places that Plato never even considered. He sees the Soul in all life. In the *De Anima*, famous treatise on the Soul, he says that all life, including vegetative life and animals, as well as human beings, have a nutritive Soul. He says that all animals, including human beings, also have a sensory Soul—that which enables us to perceive the world and engage with it.
- 5.6** And then at the top, he says, all human beings also have a rational Soul. What distinguishes us as human beings is that we have a desire to understand, a desire to engage rationally with our experience. But for Aristotle, this isn't a feature of a Soul that is, as it were, trapped in a body, as some readings of Plato might imply, but simply a feature of what we are as animals. We're the kinds of animals that are distinguished by the desire to understand. We're the only sorts of animals who will listen to lectures on Plato, on difficult philosophical topics. If you think about it, this is a very strange form of behavior in the animal kingdom. What's the evolutionary payoff of lectures on Plato?
- 5.7** So the Soul is everywhere, just as the Forms are everywhere. He's not rejecting Plato, he's turbocharging Plato. It's sometimes said that Aristotle is an Empiricist focused on Experience, whereas Plato is a Rationalist focused on Reason. Now, there's some truth to that textbook story. But if you look carefully in Aristotle, you see that the world of biology, the study of biology, which he largely invents, and the world of physics, is just the first stop on the journey. He's fascinated by mathematics, and he's fascinated by metaphysics. And at the end of one of the greatest, possibly the greatest treatise on Ethics—the moral life ever written, the *Nicomachean Ethics* in Book 10, the final book of that text he insists that the highest form of human life is Contemplation. Contemplation of the Truth, contemplation of the Good. That's not a very Empiricist conclusion.
- 5.8** He's also committed to seeing hierarchy in the world. And at the very peak of this hierarchy, he sees God, or perhaps better, more accurately described, he sees what he says is an unmoved mover. Thought thinking itself—*nous noesis*, *noeseos*. This a kind of cosmic narcissist, contemplating, thought contemplating itself. Immaterial thought, contemplating itself. And all the entirety of the universe in spacetime, the natural world, is yearning for this Being, is Ordered towards it. There's a strong teleology there—teleology meaning simply a way in which something is oriented towards an end, towards a final horizon. A teleological system is a purposive system. It's directed, it's oriented. Something that reductive Ionian naturalists and sophists were very suspicious

of. If you're a materialist or an atomist, you're going to be much more attracted to the idea of randomness and chance than overriding purpose.

5.9 But both Aristotle and Plato, in his own way, are committed to hierarchy and to teleology, to orientation, final purposiveness. And so in all of these ways, I think we can say that Aristotle is one of the greatest, if not the greatest, Platonist. That's a little heretical for some as a position, but I'm going to put it out there because most of the other lectures and textbooks that you come across are likely to tell you a very different story, the standard story. So I put that out there for you to consider and to play with.

5.10 We're going to jump ahead a little bit now because I want to move from the Hellenic towards the Hebraic. Up until now, we haven't really touched on theology. We haven't really touched on God and questions involving God and divinity as they've been understood and unpacked within the Abrahamic monotheistic traditions. But it's part of the extraordinary story of Plato's afterlives that his legacy is interwoven in all sorts of fascinating and influential ways, with ideas from the Hebrew scriptures and from the New Testament.

5.11 The first key figure in this story is Philo of Alexandria. He's born, I think, roughly 20 BC. So he's really a figure from the first century, sort of straddles the first century BC, first century AD. And Philo is formed in the great city of Alexandria, a city that is just fizzing with intellectual energy and infrastructure—the Mouseion, a great sort of university, a gathering place for scholars, an extraordinary library in which scholars drew texts together, commented on them, organized them and began—it's the first sort of time at which, first point at which all of human knowledge begins to be systematized and understood as, say, knowledge all around the Mediterranean world. And it fuses, as it were, within this city we have very sophisticated Jewish intellectual culture.

5.12 The Old Testament, the Hebrew scriptures are translated by 70 scholars allegedly in round about 3rd-2nd century BC. And so that Greek translation of the Hebrew scriptures becomes known as the Septuagint, septuaginta, meaning being 70 in Latin. But it's also the center of the Hellenistic world. It's named after Alexander the Great, that figure who sweeps down from Macedonia and conquers a greater landmass than almost any military leader in history and dies very young, and in the aftermath of that, Alexandria is founded. So it's an extremely important center for Greek intellectual life. I should add that Alexander the Great's private tutor was none other than Aristotle himself, who died just a year after his pupil in 322. Fascinating strand of continuity there.

5.13 So Philo of Alexandria, he's growing up in this extraordinary city. And Philo claims that Moses must have had a Greek education. And his theory is that Moses learnt his science and philosophy through the sort of Hellenic strand in Egypt at the court of Pharaoh, because Pythagoras had visited Egypt and had, as it were, brought Greek ideas, Greek scientific and philosophical ideas, to Egypt. Now, of course, needless to say, the chronology and the history is mad and couldn't possibly work. But it's a very

interesting little glimpse into the self-understanding of Philo. He wants a backdrop, he wants a historical narrative to, as it were, justify and illuminate his great enterprise.

- 5.14** What was that enterprise? Well, he wrote a very great deal, but one of the most fascinating texts for me is the *De Opificio Mundi*—it's a Latin title, *On the Creation of the World*, on the manufacture of the world. And in this fascinating treatise, he fuses Plato's *World of the Forms* and in particular the figure of the Demiurge in Plato's *Timaeus*, where there's a God who kind of brings order, an artisanal God, a sort of workman God, who brings order out of chaos and imposes structure through geometry and mathematics on the natural world.
- 5.15** Philo fuses those ideas with the creation narrative and the creationist framework of *Genesis*. And it's a fascinating moment in the history of ideas. Philosophy meets theology, Plato's *Forms* become— the story is complicated but roughly speaking— Plato's *Forms* become God's thoughts, the creative blueprint, the architect's plan for the design of the world. And these thoughts, says Philo, can be understood and distilled into a single pregnant Greek word, "*Logos*". If you try and look *logos* up in a Greek dictionary, you'll see that there are pages and pages and pages of different attempts to pin down and define that word. It can mean speech, it can mean reason, it can mean a kind of rational principle. It's a very slippery semantic. It's got very slippery semantics.
- 5.16** But Philo's idea is that the *Logos* is what informs the creator's agency, the creative act. And the *logos* is, it's immaterial, it's the thoughts, as it were, in the mind of God. And this is an extremely important confluence of the two traditions. And so when we see in the New Testament the language in the famous opening verses of John's Gospel, "*En arkhē ēn ho logos*", in the beginning was the *Logos*. And when John goes on to identify that *Logos* with Jesus Christ, we start to see a further layer being added to this fascinating fusion between the Hellenic and the Hebraic. It's not for nothing that Nietzsche claimed that Christianity is Platonism for the masses. It's Platonism made intelligible, Platonism given a story in the life of that particular human being.
- 5.17** Now, this move, this fusion—though, in Philo of Alexandria, we have a Jewish thinker— this confluence of ideas persists through into early Christian thought. We see it in the figure of Origen of Alexandria, who is an obsessive reader of Plato. And we see it too, in the great figure of Augustine, 354- 430, so we're jumping, jumping ahead. Augustine grows up drinking at the well of the neo-Platonists. He talks about how he came across some "*Libri Platonicī*", some Platonic books. Scholars are pretty sure that he didn't really read any of Plato's *Dialogues*. There's not much evidence that he could read Greek. Almost certainly he couldn't read Greek. And he didn't really have access to Plato's *Dialogues*, but he did have access to many texts in Latin that were mediating the great Platonic tradition. Because all sorts of schools claiming the mantle of Plato had opened up in the wake of Plato's death. And the academy is still going, the academy in Athens is still going and is still preserving Plato's legacy.

- 5.18** And Augustine says it makes so much more sense for ideas to be, for thoughts, Forms, immaterial entities to be grounded in mind. How can we have thoughts without a thinker? The word idea implies thought, as opposed to a kind of strange, abstract metaphysical cloud floating in Plato's heaven. They are thoughts. And so Augustine wants to give Plato's ideas a kind of change of metaphysical address, and he shifts them and locates them and grounds them in the Divine Mind. This is roughly the strategy that Philo adopts.
- 5.19** But I think Augustine sees the philosophical and theoretical power of doing this in a way that perhaps Philo misses. Augustine sees that there's a huge advantage to having ideas as thoughts grounded in the mind of a person. Mathematical propositions, the $2+2=4$, $1+1=2$. We talked about this the other day, it's status. Is it something that we just dream up, or is it something we discover? It's a conceptual, it's an activity of thought, a mathematical proposition, thinks Augustine. It can't just be cut off. It's got to be anchored in a thinker. It makes a lot more sense for that sort of entity to be grounded in a mind.
- 5.20** And I think we've got a more intelligible picture with Augustine. No doubt all kinds of thoughts are going through your mind at the moment. We can get a grip on the idea that we have countlessly many thoughts, but they are all anchored and unified in a single mind—you, me. And Augustine plays with this idea a great deal, particularly in his famous treatise *On The Trinity*. So you can think about three-in-oneness in the same way that you can think about the different features of our soul—memory, will, understanding— as being anchored in one. The three are in one.
- 5.21** We've talked a little bit about Jung and Dr. Peterson's desire to bring the archetypes back into contemporary thought, and it's been pretty successful. But we've talked in previous lectures also about the way in which archetypes are, if they're just grounded in human beings, would seem to be kind of purely contingent, just as we are contingent. We're here today, we're gone tomorrow. And if the archetypes are tapping into or exemplifying eternal truths about reality, ultimate meaning, then there's something a little bit unsettling about the fact that archetypes are just grounded in human minds, not just because we're here today, gone tomorrow, does that just mean ultimate meaning depends on us and vanishes with us? But also because it's not clear, as we've talked about before, how these archetypes emerge, if they're just emerging in this sort of Darwinian process, then there's no ultimate meaning necessarily in the archetypes. It's not clear how the archetypes are aligning us with ultimate reality. The archetypes are presumably just there because there's some evolutionary benefit to them being there.
- 5.22** As Richard Dawkins says, "DNA neither knows nor cares." We dance to its music. DNA just is, just cares about survival, not truth, certainly not ultimate meaning. But I think we see in Augustine's move a way to strengthen Jung. If we can see the archetypes as located not in finite, fragile, and, in Augustine's view, fallen minds, but in a timeless,

perfect, Divine Mind, there's a way of beginning to understand what the archetypes disclose as being something that provides a source of ultimate meaning. It's ultimate. There's nothing more ultimate than a God who is the source of all being and all goodness, who exists necessarily outside time, outside space, and immune to the ravages of space and time.

- 5.23** Now, that's a little speculative, and I'm not sure if you've followed me there, and I don't know of any literature on this, but I simply wanted to bring in, given that this is the Peterson Academy, I wanted to bring in that sort of Jungian twist to our lightning tour of Plato's afterlives.
- 5.24** Another interesting dimension to this Hebraic/ Hellenic marriage is how God is understood in terms of essence and existence. Forms are essences in Plato, and Forms are essences in Aristotle. And there was historically a great deal of excitement when the Greek world began to wrestle with God's self-revelation to Moses in Exodus 3:14. In which Moses asks, "Who should I say sent me?" And God replies, "I Am who I Am." That's who you should say sent you. That's who you should say to the Israelites, you were sent by, "I Am who I Am." What on earth is going on there?
- 5.25** The writer of Exodus is not doing philosophy, but it seems as if we have, in this moment of divine revelation, a claim that the source of all reality is a timeless present, is not caught up in time, and the source of all reality has an essence that is also his existence. What do we mean by that? What we mean by that is that what God is is the same as the fact that he is. God's essence is his existence. There's no distinction between those two.
- 5.26** For us, we've got essences, 32 teeth, two hands, ten fingers, and so on. But it's not part of our essence that we actually exist. We may well not exist, might die tomorrow, we may never have existed. But the claim of subsequent interpreters of that extraordinary verse, Exodus 3:14, insisted that God is the ultimate source of all existence, because there is no difference between what He is and the fact that He is—no difference at all. And He can therefore be the ultimate explanation for all of those things that follow, whose essence is not to exist.
- 5.27** This is very important, by the way, when we come to think about contemporary existentialists, particularly in the francophone world, who are obsessed with the question of existence and think that we've got to get rid of talk of essences. And this picture allows us to fuse these two together. So, Exodus 3:14, we have something like an ultimate Platonic reality, something like the Platonic Good, beyond Being, it's the source of all Being, the source of existence. But with one of the O's taken out.
- 5.28** Let's move on now to a final chapter in this story. And this phase begins with the Dialogue, the Timaeus, the late Dialogue, Plato's late Dialogue, the Timaeus, which we've talked about before. It's a very unusual Dialogue, in which Plato lays out a whole theory of the physical world, a whole theory of nature, as being soaked with

purposiveness, being directed towards an end. It's being soaked with intelligibility. And it's clear that what he was trying to do was to resist the Ionian materialists who said, it's all matter. There's no rhyme or reason, it's just chance, no way of explaining this. The only intelligibility we can find is intelligibility that we lay onto nature ourselves, that we construct. We're not discovering it.

- 5.29 And the claim in this Dialogue is that it's mathematics underpinning all of physical reality—not stuff, not atoms, not water molecules, as for Thales or fire, as for Heraclitus, or air, as for Anaximenes—a kind of immaterial mathematical structure shows rational, it's ordered, patterned.
- 5.30 Now, this little Dialogue, which, as I said, is not representative really, of the rest of the Dialogues. This strange god, this Demiurge, this craftsman god, doesn't appear anywhere else, and there's nothing else in Plato's work that comes close to this kind of creation narrative. It's very puzzling. And yet it becomes, for many centuries, the most influential Platonic Dialogue. And in some ways, the distillation, it's assumed to be the distillation of his thought.
- 5.31 Cicero translated it into Latin and then it survived in fragments through the 1st millennium. There was a guy called Calcidius, who also translated it and commented on it. And it's in this form that it began to exercise enormous influence. And its importance and the reason it became so popular and influential, presumably, is that it underwrote, kind of guaranteed, through reason and through philosophy, what had been taught in revelation. Hey, we've got this brilliant philosopher using reason alone from the Hellenic world. He's basically got to Genesis, and yet that's what was revealed, just revealed to Moses. Moses didn't, as it were, reason his way to this. It was revealed. So maybe reason and revelation are not in conflict. Maybe faith and reason don't need to be opposed as is, of course, the central assumption of modern critiques of religion—you can't be a scientist and a believer, you can't be rational and faithful and religious.
- 5.32 What we see in these very sophisticated intellectual traditions is a fusion of truths that are believed to be revealed and truths that are believed to be discovered through reason. And there's no real distinction between these two. And that is, whatever one thinks of it, an important convergence to reflect upon, particularly in a world that insists on separating them, that insists that any scientific account of the world must exclude theological accounts of the world or teleological accounts of the world, accounts of the world that say that the world is purposive, that there's meaning.
- 5.33 You can't even start to talk about meaning if you think that ultimately everything is just matter—all reality is blind, purposeless matter. Now, meaning and faith are not the same things, but it may be that you reject religion, would reject God, but still think, there must be meaning to my life, there must be meaning to the world. It seems so intelligible, seems so laced with significance. I don't really want the God stuff, but at the same time, do I really want to commit myself to the idea that I'm completely mistaken about these intuitions, that there's more to life than just matter? That I matter, and

that the people I love matter? If you're completely committed to the claim that reason excludes purpose, then it's going to be very difficult to live a life of meaning, or rather, it's going to be very difficult for you to live as if there were some ultimate meaning that was deeper than mere matter.

- 5.34** Part of the Platonic legacy which gets, as it were, baptized by the Abrahamic traditions is this thought that they are layers and degrees to reality, as well as there being a purpose to reality. This is sometimes called the Ladder of Nature, the Ladder of Being, the Scala Naturae, or in the phrase of the great Harvard historian of ideas, Arthur Lovejoy—great name—the "Great Chain of Being", the Great Chain of Being. It's like a waterfall of Being. And at the very bottom of that waterfall, of that chain, you've got mere matter. And as you move up, you get matter with form. You get vegetative life, animal life, human beings, and then angels and principalities and so on. And you move all the way up to a Divine source right at the top. In the neo-Platonic tradition, so-called, developed by Plotinus roughly 200- 270AD, and his followers, Lamblichus in particular, and Proclus, we have this idea that there's a kind of trinitarian structure, except it's not equal, as in the Christian Trinity. You've got the World Soul, and then you've got "Nous" or Intelligence, a kind of realm of thinking. And then beyond this, simply "to éna"—the One. We don't need to go down that Plotinian rabbit hole, but I put it in there just because it's a very important engine for this idea of there being a hierarchy to all reality.
- 5.35** This way of thinking about reality is one that begins to meet enormous criticism as the 1300s, 1400s come around. And what we see in this phase, what we see in this short space of time, is a complete collapse of this way of understanding reality. This Platonic hierarchy and structure to reality happens very quickly indeed. It's what C. S. Lewis calls in one of his last books—in fact, I think it was published after he died—The Discarded Image, The Discarded Image has a huge impact, not just on philosophy and theology, but also on literature in particular. That was Lewis's focus. Because with the collapse of the Great Chain of Being, it ceased to be possible to understand the world as enchanted in some way, as there being more to the world than meets the eye. And that is going to be one of the focuses of our next lecture.
- 5.36** But to close this lecture, I want to say a little bit about how that disintegration happened. A key figure, not the only figure, but a key figure, is William of Ockham from England—medieval philosopher— Ockham is in Surrey, near London. And Ockham's claim, put very crudely, is that all this talk of Forms and essences and universals was gibberish. We can't see them. And all this talk of there being a divine mind containing Plato's heaven was also utterly implausible. The only way to think about God is in terms not of mind, but of power and will. And if God has a mind but we can't, how could we trace the thoughts of God? How could we have any access to the thoughts of God? God's outside the cave, but we can't get out there. We're in the cave. It would be somehow impious to think we could just walk up outside the cave and understand

God's thoughts. There's a kind of theological impulse to that, a sort of strange piety. All we can know is what God tells us to do, what God wills.

5.37 And so the Great Chain of Being starts to be dismantled. Skepticism starts to bleed into European thought. And it's not just skepticism about how we understand the world and physical reality and nature. It's skepticism about the moral universe, too, the moral world. We can't understand the Good in God because all that goodness can be is obeying the divine will. That's what we can grasp. We can grasp what God has told us to do, and that's morality—the obligations that come from God's commands and instructions. And the stress here, of course, is on what we see, what we grasp, and there's a suspicion of reason, a stress which gives way to a stress on experience.

5.38 Some historians think this was a very positive development. You might do, too. One of the ways that it's thought to be positive is that it's thought to have laid the seeds for scientific inquiry, for the natural sciences. Why? Well, if we can't, as it were, have any access to God's creative blueprint, as we have in the *Timaeus* and in Philo of Alexandria and in Augustine and others, we haven't got any sense of the scheme that renders reality, nature legible. Well, we've got to get up off our armchairs and go and inspect the world. We've got to experiment on the world. And we can't just assume that for every experiment we run, we're discerning some divine pattern and thought. So the skepticism, some historians think, is a motor to scientific inquiry in that way.

5.39 And so we come now, really, with the figure of Ockham and his doctrine of nominalism, as it's called, to the threshold of modernity. We have, as it were, the first seeds sown of skepticism about the Platonic inheritance. I should say a word briefly about Nominalism. What do I mean by the word "Nominalism"? The Latin word for names is "nomina". This is why we call it Nominalism. And Ockham's thesis, or at least the thesis of his followers, is that we shouldn't be talking about Forms and essences, things that are actually out there in the world that we discover and we don't construct. What we're doing, really what we're doing is we're simply, when we think we're discovering essences, we're just attaching names. We're just attaching names to things.

5.40 So being human is not exemplifying some form of being human in Plato's heaven, or in a theological sense. Being human is not imaging God, being godlike. It's a kind of Platonic way of thinking of that idea in Genesis—God up there, and human beings are imaging Him—this is nonsense for Ockham. Being human is just a name. It's a phrase that we construct and then just attach to these featherless bipeds. And these featherless bipeds don't have anything in common at all beyond the fact that we've decided to collect them together as a class. We've decided to organize them. We human beings have decided to organize them this way. There is no essence to lions. Lion is just the sound, it's the name that we attach to that collection which we almost arbitrarily gather together.

5.41 It's a strange thought, but it's one that becomes enormously influential. There are no essences, there's no participation in Platonic Forms, there's no exemplification of

Divine ideas. It's simply up to us to carve up the world as we decide. It's up to the sciences in particular to decide how the world ought to be carved up. And that map is going to change the whole time as we discover more ways of thinking about the world.

- 5.42 And so, as I said, with these seeds of skepticism, we come to the threshold of modernity. Modernity being in the history of philosophy, roughly speaking, 1600 onwards. We talk of the early modern philosophers—and that would be Descartes, for example, 1596- 1650—he is early modern. This is one of the difficult things about using words like "modern" to describe a period. Modern refers to a time, or strictly speaking, modern means "now" in Latin. The trouble with now is it has the unfortunate habit of quickly becoming then. And so we get modernism being a particular period, roughly 100 years ago, and then we have postmodernism. Time has the unfortunate habit of passing. So early modernity 1600 onwards, and that's appropriate, I think, because it's at this moment that we have at this juncture that we have an entirely new way of thinking about reality, one that largely defines itself by the rejection of the Platonic inheritance, the collapse of the Great Chain of being. And with that, we can come on to the 6th and final lecture, where we will look not just at Plato's afterlives but Plato's Resurrections. Thanks for listening. Questions.
- 5.43 Yes, so my first question also has to do with yesterday's lecture, but it relates to today's as well. And it's that in Plato's Academy it said, "Let no man enter here who is ignorant of either geometry or mathematics." I forget which one was the word. And you said that he placed a lot of emphasis on learning geometry and astronomy because they relate to mathematics. I was wondering why the emphasis on geometry? Because technically, geometry has to do with the ordering of the universe—forms, our bodies, planets, rocks. But what does it have to do with how we relate to one another? What does it have to do with ethics? So why does he place prime importance on something that maybe doesn't have to do with that?
- 5.44 It's a great question. Thank you for raising it. I think the importance of mathematics and geometry for Plato, and the reason he requires his future Philosopher Rulers to spend years and years studying geometry, is not because geometry is somehow a subset or even a kind of conceptual prelude to ethics, but more because the analogy between geometry and the Good is close enough to help us to think in the right way and be ready help the Philosopher Rulers to be ready to contemplate the Good in the right way. Because the Good shares certain characteristics with geometric forms—immaterial. They were accessed by the mind and not the senses. They are spaceless, outside space. They are timeless, and they are, to some extent, he thinks, explanatory or part of the ultimate structure of nature. In the *Timaeus*, he says at one point that the reason that this craftsman god put the stars and the sun in the sky was to teach us mathematics. Why? Well, partly, maybe to attune us to the Good, but also the claim in the *Timaeus* is that really nature is made up of triangles at the bottom. They're immaterial, structuring principles that renders nature intelligible.

- 5.45 So it's not as if geometry is somehow part of ethics, or even at all the same thing as ethics in terms of its subject matter, but more that the objects of geometric inquiry, and the ultimate object of moral inquiry, the Good, share many characteristics. And yet geometry is much easier, Plato thinks, to sort of adjust our minds to and to train ourselves in. But it can help us, therefore, to prepare, to contemplate and grasp the Good. And the key thing, I think, is that it moves us away from the sensory world, which, for Plato, is unstable and is never going to be able to anchor true beliefs about the moral life. And the pathway to that is, through geometry and mathematics.
- 5.46 So does studying geometry and mathematics come first, or does studying the architecture of your own soul and your good come first?
- 5.47 It's assumed that you understand yourself as an ensouled being. So the Philosopher Ruler will understand himself as an ensouled being and a Well-Ordered Soul with a reason in control of Spirit and Appetite and Reason, therefore prepared, only a Well-Ordered Soul can embark on the study of geometry and thereafter be prepared and trained for contemplation and understanding of "to Agathon", of the Good.
- 5.48 Professor, since many things have a telos, naturally different entities, and such a telos is based on the nature of the thing in and of itself, how did Ockham get away with it? Did he sidestep it? Did he critique it?
- 5.49 So Ockham and Ockham's followers became skeptical that essences and Forms and particularly final purpose— teloi, was something that were empirically available. And all that could be seen in this way of thinking is just objects, Forms, and final purposes are something that is not immediately available in this mindset to perception. We can't strictly see it. It's a very radical form of empiricism. What I see is not a particular kind of thing when I see a lion, a species that belongs to a genus, as it were, that kind of is part of an objectively existing structure of organic life. I just see a furry four-legged thing, and I have an impulse to kind of make sense of the world and categorize it. So I'm going to say, "Well, I think that there is some resemblance here. The resemblance that I see, I perceive as really resemblance that I recognize, not that I discern necessarily as existing in the world. And then I'm going to generate these categories and classifications, and I'm going to add my nomen, leo, to that category." Yes.
- 5.50 So this is going back a little bit. I've been struggling with that section where you talked about defining courage specifically. I'm still kind of working through my question. Because it seemed to me like very honestly linguistic in nature, and that makes the most sense to me, but I know that they're trying to relate it back to the Good in some sort of way, correct? So if they're doing that, in defining courage are they trying to simply differentiate between virtues? And is that important to do, or can we just attribute it ultimately?
- 5.51 It's a great question. Thank you. Absolutely. So going back, the question of what is courage? —"Ti esti andreia?"—it's the central question of the early Socratic Dialogue,

the Laches, with this general, who we all, Socrates assumes, and we all assume to be an expert on courage. And what's going on there can seem like a merely linguistic exercise. Just an exercise in working out what we Athenians mean when we're talking about *andreia* and courage. But what Socrates is introducing is the thought that, no, there is, if we're going to be talking about anything at all, we're actually going to be talking about reality. There has to be some objective form or essence to this virtue where we can say all of those instances are instances of courage because of this, because they satisfy this particular definition. But the definition, although it will be expressed linguistically, is supposed to be hooking onto some underlying feature of reality or human behavior.

5.52 Now, courage is one of the four cardinal virtues, and, as it were, is therefore obviously a virtue. It's not just any old virtue, but a central virtue. And there's a lot of debate about this, but Plato thinks of the virtues as having a unity, as fitting together, and courage, as it were, has a place in that. So courage is exemplifying the Good in particular contexts where the Good needs to be exemplified in that way. Some scholars think that actually there's a sort of separate form of courage, but they're all ultimately linked up to Good at the top, as it were.

5.53 So then what is the utility in differentiating between the virtues?

5.54 Because Goodness will exemplify itself in different contexts, and it's useful for training in the moral life and the formation of character to be able to distinguish different expressions, different Forms of the Good. And it's just a philosophical claim of Plato's that all of these different virtues are, as it were, unified and anchored in an ultimate Good. Yes.

5.55 So this question is also a little bit of a comment— I'm still working through it as well— but I want to learn, understand more about the Doctrine of Nominalism, and the idea that we just basically label things—which I find pretty ironic, also a little bit funny— because they're saying, "Oh, we just label things, and then we carve out our world by scientific discovery and things." But science itself is based on things like axioms, like what we were talking about, " $1+1=2$," or "a line can only go through two points." If you think about it that way, those axioms themselves can be considered an essence, because we can't really discover it. So how do they explain that? You know what I mean?

5.56 I do. It's a brilliant question. And it's a question that both criticizes, sort of develops a very powerful criticism of nominalism and takes us conveniently on to the next lecture. Because one of the Forms that Plato's resurrection takes, I'm going to argue, is as a response to the kind of criticism that you've developed there, namely, how is it that we can simply abandon mathematics. That doesn't seem very easily assimilated into the nominalistic picture, though some have tried. How can we just abandon that when the more science we do, the more mathematical it gets? A lot of physics just now is only mathematics. I mean, our powers of mathematical discovery vastly outstrip our

technological capacity to test our scientific speculations worked out in mathematics. So you're absolutely right.

5.57 You also raise the question of logic. So logical axioms like the law of non-contradiction, the so-called Laws of Thought. That is also a very difficult objection for the nominalist to counter, because it seems as if the nominalist is presupposing in any argument, in saying anything at all, that there are these immaterial patterns for thought, and you can't ditch those. You might say, "Oh, there are no laws of nature. It's just kind of accidental regularities." But you can't just ditch the laws of thought. Because if you did, then thought would stop. If you ditch the law, that X and not X can't be the same thing at the same time, in the same place —if you ditch that law, then you can't argue, you can't have any kind of discussion at all. So these are big challenges for the nominalists, and we'll see why in more detail in the 6th and final lecture. Thank you.

Lecture 6: Plato Today

At a glance — The final lecture considers Plato today — broadly, the last several centuries — arguing that a recognizably Platonic worldview still shapes how we think about truth, reality, and value, and asking what remains living in it.

- 6.1** Our final lecture—lecture 6—Plato Today. As I said at the end of the last lecture, today is doing a lot of work. By today, I'm encompassing, really, the last 400 years. But I think I can get away with that, because I think the worldview, the outlook, the kind of fabric of our understanding of the world, of morality, of meaning, of nature and so on, is very roughly beginning 400 years ago. This is the Dawn of the so-called Enlightenment. I think I said in an earlier lecture that we have to be very careful with the labels we use to describe the past. Remember modernity. Modernity, as a label, ties itself to the now, which quickly becomes then, and so it becomes definitionally useless.
- 6.2** Well, think here about the term enlightenment. Enlightenment is a description for, in this case, as describing a historical period, a label that presupposes that what came before was darkness and confusion. Anyone who's read a little bit of St. Augustine or Anselm or Aquinas or Bonaventure or even William of Ockham will know that they were not darkened minds. They did not have darkened minds. They were brilliant figures, figures who illuminated our understanding of the world.
- 6.3** But the way we carve up history can often tell a very particular and slanted story. Think, for example, of the word Renaissance—which is beginning roughly a little bit earlier than the Enlightenment, 15th century Florence, probably—rebirth. What comes before rebirth? Death. So we have periods of darkness, periods of death issuing in moments, phases of enlightenment and rebirth. And what I want to just put on the table for you is the idea that the story we tell ourselves about reality and our place within it is today heavily conditioned by skepticism towards the outlooks that came before the phases that we describe, with terms like Enlightenment and Renaissance. So be skeptical of those terms, even if you don't really have any choice but to use them.
- 6.4** So we stand at the threshold of the so-called Enlightenment. And yet the philosophy that emerges first, certainly in England, is the philosophy of Thomas Hobbes. Thomas Hobbes—1588- 1679, I think—very long life—was a materialist and a figure who has a lot of echoes of the figures we met in the first book of Plato's Republic, the Thrasymachus, and the figure we met in the Gorgias, Callicles, Polus, and particularly Callicles.
- 6.5** Hobbes is a figure who is skeptical of the idea that there is any objective moral order. Thinks that claims, talk about morality, is really a cloak for the assertion of raw power. There's certainly not on this picture, sometimes called Corpuscularianism, which is really a version of materialism—everything's just matter all the way down. There's no room, of course, for talk of ensoulment—having a soul. There's no sense in which we

can use the word Good or Just. There's no sense in which we can talk about nature as being ordered or oriented or directed or being purposive. And there's certainly no talk of God. And with this philosophy comes the claim that human society, if left to its own devices, would degenerate into a "bellum omnium contra omnes"—a war of all against all. And what's required to keep in check our natural tendencies for conflict is a supremely powerful state—"leviathan", in his formulation. So again, we talk about this doesn't feel like a very enlightened, or at least enlightened in the sense of positive, outlook. And as I said, it doesn't feel particularly new. We've seen this before, we've seen this materialism before, we've seen this cynicism before, long ago in Plato.

- 6.6 But Platonism is still alive. It's still alive and kicking—just. There was, for example, a group of Platonists gathered in Cambridge, in England, the so-called Cambridge Platonists—Ralph Cudworth and Henry More being some of the most notable—who reacted against Hobbes and drew on Platonic insights and ideas to say, "No, this is not the case. Human beings have an inner light, a candle of the Lord. They have an attunement to ultimate reality. They have a mind that is more than mere matter. It's more than just a receptacle for sense experience. So you see that back and forth, but really it's the Hobbesians and the materialists who have the upper hand.
- 6.7 And you see, emerging in early modern philosophy—this is a little bit crude, but basically correct—a split between two traditions, rationalist tradition figures like Descartes and Leibniz and Spinoza, figures who stress reason as being the main tool we use to understand reality. And there's a kind of accompanying suspicion of sense experience. And on the other hand, you've got the Brits, broadly speaking, the empiricist tradition, John Locke, George Berkeley and David Hume. As I said, this is a slightly crude picture, but I sketch it out just for simplicity. And you might say that the World of the Sun has gone with a rationalist tradition, and the World of the Cave has gone with the empiricist tradition. There's no longer any story, really, of how these two might fit together. There's a kind of mutual suspicion.
- 6.8 Now of course, there's a suspicion, too, in Plato. There's a suspicion of sense experience in Plato. But in Plato, there's a story about how these two fit together. There's a story about how we move from the world of sense experience to the world of intelligible Forms. And we'll come on to talk a bit more about that towards the end of the lecture.
- 6.9 What we're going to focus on for the rest of the lecture is 3 aspects of Plato's, 3 platonic resurrections, 3 ways in which Platonic ideas come back to the fore in modernity—mathematics, meaning, and myth. First off, mathematics—what is it about mathematics that brings Plato back? There's a great physicist in England, he's still alive, he's just won the Nobel Prize, called Sir Roger Penrose. Sir Roger Penrose, with Stephen Hawking, was one of the cosmologists who played a huge role in establishing the theory of the Big Bang in the 1960s. And a few years ago, Penrose wrote this fascinating book called *The Road to Reality: A Complete Guide to the Laws of the Universe*.

- 6.10** Now, he is unimpeachable as an authority within the world of science, as I said, Nobel Prize winner and a brilliant cosmologist and physicist. But in this book, he made some startling claims, these startling claims, given the history of the last 400 years, and its rejection of the Platonic legacy. What he said was that reality is made up of 3 worlds. There's the world of the mind, which reflects the physical world, should say, starts with the physical world. All scientists agree with that, certainly all materialists agree with that. There's the mental world. That's already starting to be controversial—the claim that there's a mental reality, consciousness, that is actually distinct from the material world and not just reducible to brain states. That already is starting to be, starting to resist the claim that all truths are to be understood in scientific terms, that the mind is just the brain. But he goes on to posit a 3rd world, and that world is the mathematical world. And Penrose insists that in order to grasp the deeper structures of physical reality, one must presuppose the existence of a domain of mathematical truths. In effect, one must presuppose the existence of a platonic mathematical reality. Plato, it seems, is back, at least for Sir Roger Penrose.
- 6.11** Now, this throws up all kinds of puzzles. How, for example, could it be the case that the mathematical world is so intertwined with the physical world? This is very puzzling. They're two completely different kinds of world, immaterial and the material. How is it that we need maths when we're trying to work out how to build a bridge? Maths and numbers and calculations. Our mind is as if we're accessing something that seems to be beyond the world of stuff and atoms and laws of nature. This is what a philosopher called Eugene Wigner said in 1961—what he described as the unreasonable effectiveness of mathematics in the natural sciences. He said this, "The miracle of the appropriateness of the language of mathematics for the formulation of the laws of physics is a wonderful gift, which we neither understand nor deserve. We should be grateful for it and hope that it will remain valid in future research and that it will extend, for better or for worse, to our pleasure, even though perhaps also to our bafflement to wide branches of learning."
- 6.12** So Wigner says, it's a gift, and we didn't understand it, it's unreasonable, but the two have to go together. The mathematical realm, the Platonic realm, is perfectly interwoven with the natural world Being and Becoming, Parmenides and Heraclitus, sunlight and cavelight, Sun World and Cave World. And it's true, we see, for example, way before Penrose and way before Wigner, examples of mathematics, this distinct world leading to extraordinary discoveries in the physical world.
- 6.13** Copernicus speculated that the mathematics, used mathematics to speculate that the planets must revolve around the sun, not around the earth—shift from geocentrism to heliocentrism. And sure enough, further down the line, experience confirmed reason. Scientific discoveries confirmed mathematical theorizing. The two worlds came together. Kepler used mathematics to develop the foundations of celestial mechanics, mechanics of movements in the heavens. Galileo brought a lot of those mathematical

insights to bear on mechanics down here on earth. And Newton's genius was to fuse both of them together.

- 6.14** But again, these insights are borrowed, as it were, from a timeless, spaceless realm, from Plato's heaven, it seems, and applied perfectly to the messy world of matter and chance and natural laws. And so this is the puzzle. And Sir Roger Penrose, in the book that I mentioned, concluded in this way, he said, "Does the Platonic mathematical world actually exist in any meaningful sense? Many people, including philosophers, might regard such a world as a complete fiction." And that's the story, as I've suggested since 1600. Of course it's a fiction. We got rid of that a long time ago with William of Ockham and with Hobbes and with Hume and with others. "And yet," he continues, "the Platonic viewpoint is indeed an immensely valuable one. It tells us to be careful to distinguish the precise mathematical entities from the approximations that we see around us in the world of physical things."
- 6.15** What does he mean by that? There are no perfect circles down here, as it were in the cave. There'll always be some imperfection to any circle we try to come up with. But how could we even think of an imperfect circle as being imperfect if we're not approximating it to some perfect circle?, is the thought. There must be some benchmark for perfection. Now, of course, the Platonist thinks there is, as it were, such a geometric form out there against which we can approximate and measure circles down here. And others will say, no, this is a fiction, a convenient fiction that we imagine.
- 6.16** Penrose says, "The Platonic viewpoint provides us with the blueprint according to which modern science has proceeded ever since, for the last few centuries. Our individual minds are notoriously imprecise, unreliable, inconsistent. The precision and the reliability and the consistency required by our scientific theories demand something beyond any one of our individual untrustworthy minds. In mathematics, we find a far greater robustness, precision than can be located in any particular mind. Does this not point," he ends, "to something outside ourselves, with a reality that lies beyond what each individual can achieve?"
- 6.17** So what I want to suggest is that at the cutting edge of contemporary physics, there are some of its most brilliant exponents are making sense of their inquiry by appealing to Plato, or at least by appealing to a broadly Platonic understanding of reality as being tiered, according to which the world of sense experience and mere nature is not the end of the world, as it were, a comprehensive account of ultimate reality.
- 6.18** You get a similar sort of story happening in the philosophy of language. Snow is white. La neige est blanche. Der Schnee ist weiß. La neve è bianca. 4 sentences, completely different, made up of completely different sounds, and all yet expressing what? Another sentence? In what language is that sentence? There's a phrase that "God's language is English". I'm English, but I don't think that God's language is English. But what's going on with those 4 sentences? Those 4 sentences are conveying a truth.

Snow is white. But is there anything in the use of those sounds, "snow is white", that makes that sentence truer than "la neige est blanche"? Or how could "la neige est blanche" and "snow is white" be conveying the same truth if they're completely different sounds? What's being expressed? What is the truth that's being expressed? It's something deeper than a sentence, deeper than language. It seems to be a thought, a thought capable of being expressed in countless many languages, as many languages as you can kind of come up with and agree on.

- 6.19** So I want to suggest this is a kind of, we start to see here—as with mathematic science and the mathematical character of the sciences—start to see here a Platonic temptation, a pressure to Platonize. It's very tempting here to say, "Well, yeah, it's a thought. It's a true thought that exists independently of the natural languages that human beings happen to come up with, which particular sounds can truly express. But it's not the sounds that are the truth. The sounds are just the vehicle that happens to have emerged for that thought, expressed in English as "snow is white."
- 6.20** One of the fathers of modern logic, Gottlob Frege—Austrian philosopher of the late 19th century and early 20th century— in his Foundations of Arithmetic, suggested that there are these purely logical objects, like little Platonic thoughts. And some scholars have been tempted to describe this as a kind of logical Platonism. The thoughts are up there in Plato's heaven, and then our language, down in the cave, is what provides the vehicle for these thoughts that are kind of transcendent.
- 6.21** Now, needless to say, Frege can't really be called a Platonist. He certainly doesn't take up the vast majority of Plato's insights and ideas. But I hope you can see after, as we come to the end of these lectures, just how Platonic an approach that is. It's a thought out there. There's this kind of realm of thoughts beyond the messy world of space and time that our languages, in all of their extraordinary diversity, can convey. But it can't be the language itself that is, as it were, the thought. So mathematics and little coda on language.
- 6.22** The next M is myth. The next Platonic resurrection after mathematics is myth. We've already come up against this pair of Mythos and Logos, story and reason, story and word. And it's very tempting to think of Plato as just this strict dualist, that is to say, a philosopher of the number 2. He thinks of everything coming in pairs, visibility and invisibility, materiality and immateriality, cave and sun, animate, inanimate, and so on. But there are moments, many moments, in Plato's Dialogues where it seems as if the world that we sense and experience is, in fact, understood by Plato to be a signal of the world beyond—a signal of transcendence. In the Timaeus, which we touched on in the previous lecture, objects in the universe can be signs of, he says, "Can be imitations of those things that always are," namely, eternal Divine Forms.
- 6.23** You see it in the Phaedo, you see it in the Phaedrus, the way in which Socrates describes the beauty of a young boy attracts, sort of quickens in him a sense of that there is an ultimate Form of Beauty beyond, which the beauty of the boy instantiates,

exemplifies, conveys, just as the phrase "la neige est blanche" or "snow is white" conveys the truth, the thought expressed as snow is white.

- 6.24** So this gives us a very different way of thinking and approaching Plato from the one we get from the Platonic picture. And I might be a little bit to blame for that if you've been thinking in this two-tier way, because I think that's how we needed to lay it out. But I am now going to remind you, or note, as we go back to the cave, back down into the cave from Plato, from Book 7 of the Republic, that the flickering flames are casting shadows, because they're casting shadows from statues and artifacts that, as it were, are behind the prisoners.
- 6.25** And so the thought is that Netflix isn't complete fantasy. What you see on Instagram is not just a completely unreal world. It's rather an extremely unreliable reflection of a reality, of something that is nevertheless real somewhere. There is some kind of connection. And if you're at least attuned to the fact that the images on the back of the wall of the cave are indeed illusory, and that you need real training to work out what's real and what isn't, what's authentic and what's inauthentic, what's just posturing and performativity, and what's disclosing the real person, that's what you need. And that's possible. It's possible to do that. There is a connection to ultimate reality.
- 6.26** That connection is crucial for understanding the subsequent influence of Plato. And it's especially crucial when we come to understand the role of myth. I've said already that Plato's very suspicious of the poets. He's suspicious of Homer. Whenever Homer gets quoted in a Platonic Dialogue, you know that Socrates is going to attack it or sort of lead somebody down a pathway and then into a complete dead end.
- 6.27** But I also suggested that Plato is this consummate literary artist. He always wanted to be a tragedian. He's one of the finest and most poetic writers of Greek prose. So he does understand the importance and the power of poetry and art and music, and that's why he gets rid of them. He exiles them in Book 10 of the Republic. We can't have these people around because they're not attuned to the truth, and therefore they're going to lead people away from it. But what's very clear is that Plato is more than happy for somebody who, in his view, is aligned to the truth, to invoke the power of art and poetry and parable and story, to disclose that truth and to convey it. In other words, it is possible within Plato, and certainly this was true of those who inherited his legacy, for Mythos to disclose Logos.
- 6.28** And with that connection and the enormous debates that followed Plato, particularly in the Middle Ages, of, "How do we interpret the Timaeus? Is it a real story? Did Plato think it actually happened? How do we think of the allegory of the cave as just kind of a picture, a parable?" Well, yes, it's a picture and a parable, but it's one that discloses Truth, ultimate Truth. And so I don't think it's much of an exaggeration to say that this openness of parts of Plato's body of work to allegorical interpretation had an incalculable impact on the mythic, the literary tradition of the West, particularly in allegorical literature, so-called. I think, here in the tradition of English literature, you

could think of pretty much any other stream of European literature. Think of Edmund Spenser's *The Faerie Queene*, where lots of the knights represent different virtues, or Bunyan's *Pilgrim's Progress*, in which Christian and Evangelist represent their journey, represents an allegorical expression of the journey of the Christian soul from earth to heaven, or Shakespeare's *Tempest*—an allegory for the collision and conflict between civilization and barbarity.

- 6.29** And the thought here is that that kind of move, that sort of connection, is permissible within a Platonic framework, because the allegory is not misleading you away and just to entertain you and to kind of mesmerize you and to keep you in the chains in the bottom of the cave, but can actually give you a glimpse of capital T Truth beyond. It can give you a glimpse of ultimate reality. It can quicken your imaginative pulse and stir in you something more than just mere reason, but desire, desire for this ultimate world of the Good.
- 6.30** And it's no accident that with the decline of the Platonic tradition, we see also a decline in the allegorical tradition. And so the tradition of allegorical poetry begins to unravel as well, because I think those 2 are so complicit conceptually. The philosophy underpinning the way we understand the life of the imagination and myth and art and story are tightly interwoven. Those 2 traditions are tightly interwoven. Myth is, if you like, what connects the world of thought and imagination to reality. It can connect it as well as distract.
- 6.31** So the power of myth— one of the fascinating resurrection moments for Platonism in the 20th century in my own country—though he had enormous impact, well beyond it—is the figure of Clive Staples "Jack" Lewis, 1898-1963. The story of his conversion to Christianity is one that is describable and understandable in basically Platonic terms, and particularly in the Platonic terms, according to which the Myth cast by the flickering flames in the cave provides a clue to the Logos lying in the sunlight above it, or animating the world of the sun beyond it. Lewis said this in his *Reflections on the Psalms*, one of his last books, "There is a real connection between what Plato and the mythmakers most deeply were and meant, and what I believe to be the truth." Strange, because when he's saying at that point "what I believe to be the truth", he's talking about Christianity and he's talking about his own Christian commitments. So how is it that Plato was talking about that when he lived 500 years before any of it started?—400.
- 6.32** "I know that connection, and they do not. But it is really there. It's not an arbitrary fancy of my own, thrust upon the old words. One can, without absurdity, imagine Plato or the mythmakers, if they learn the truth that I believe, saying, 'Ah, I see. So that was what I was really talking about. Of course, that is what my words really meant. That's what my Dialogues were really getting at. But I never really knew it. I was on my way there. I was stumbling towards it correctly, but I never fully, had never fully got there.'"

Lewis imagines Plato saying to himself, if he jumped into a time machine, gone forward a thousand years.

- 6.33** And so we have here this fascinating account in the life of an Oxford academic of what he thought to be false myths, mesmerizing myths, distracting myths, in fact, providing clues. Clues that would, in his view, become, did in fact, become fact, historical fact. And so this leads us neatly onto the 3rd M —mathematics, myth, and finally, meaning.
- 6.34** What we're talking about by meaning is not something that is simply the meaning that we might find in nice stories that happen to have emerged from the campfires of our ancestors. "What do we mean by meaning?" is the old philosopher's question. "What do you mean by meaning?" Well, maybe in the Platonic context we can say, well, what meaning is, is an understanding of ultimate reality and an understanding of who we are that is true. Where we can say, well, that's the ultimate meaning. And anything that maybe gets close to it has a degree of meaning, a degree of truth. But meaning is what's rendered legible by the true myths that we tell ourselves about reality. It's as it were, meaning is what arises once we've aligned ourselves with and are truly in conformity with, the way reality ultimately is.
- 6.35** Notice how different that way of understanding meaning, that way of grasping the meaning of meaning, is from the sorts of understandings of the meaning of meaning that we come across in the West today. That's my meaning, your meaning. This is how I craft meaning for my own life. How do you craft meaning for your life? I hope you can now see at the end of these lectures that for the Platonists, this is a deeply disturbing way of talking, deeply confused and ultimately meaningless way of understanding the meaning of meaning.
- 6.36** It's a Sophistic way of thinking about the meaning of meaning. No one person possesses meaning in the sense that no one person has the power and capacity just to make something up and invest reality and invest that person's self with just meaning and construct it for no apparent, through the desires and preferences of that person. To that extent there is, meaning is not something that anyone can simply possess as their own. If meaning is to be meaningful, it must be something that is, in principle, singular, unique, shared, and true for all reality.
- 6.37** And this is the connection between maths and meaning again, right? There's something about maths which gives you the clue, the analogy. You said, "Well, I know you think that $2+2=4$. That's your mathematics." For Plato, it's just as meaningless to say that, to say, "That's your meaning, but my meaning is this," as it is to say, " $2+2=4$ is your mathematics, but it's not mine." So that Platonic insight is profoundly countercultural. It's a profoundly subversive thought, this. That it's not up to us to make up reality. It's not up to us to construct the world. It's not even up to us to construct our own identity. It's not up to me to simply construct my own identity, because most of what makes up my identity is what's given to me. Certain limits and ties are simply not possible to shake off. We may not like them, but we have to accept them. Certain meanings are

fixed. Certain essences are fixed. It's not up to us to deconstruct them and reconstruct them in our own image and according to our own desires.

- 6.38** That's a very difficult conclusion for a radical liberal to accept. As we saw when we were looking at the degeneration at the end of the republic in Plato's story of aristocracy, to timocracy, to oligarchy, to democracy, to ochlocracy and to tyranny, it's very difficult at the democracy stage as it's moving into ochlocracy. Remember what Plato says? There's freedom, total freedom, radical, raw freedom for everyone. And it's a sort of freedom that comes from flatness, from a flat society—no hierarchies, no apportioning of different skill sets to different parts within a society, no real authority. It's just anarchy emerges.
- 6.39** And you can't have laws. You can't have the sorts of laws you might find in a city-state, but also you can't have the kind of laws that are laws that are woven into the fabric of reality, including the kind of thing that you are. You can't free yourself. You can't not be your parent's child. You can't not be the son or daughter of that pair of human beings, whether you like them or not. There are certain limits that not even the liberal, not even the radical liberal can liberate themselves from. The Platonic picture insists on structure, on hierarchy, on purposiveness, on capital T Truth and capital M meaning, whether we like it or not. It's given, it's not constructed. It's given, so it can't be deconstructed.
- 6.40** In the 7th and final Chronicle of Narnia, Lewis describes Aslan, the great Christ-like figure of the Narnia novels, describes him taking the so-called friends to a true version of Narnia. The previous Narnia having been sort of imperfect, sort of shadow of the real Narnia. And the professor Diggory Kirk, who we first meet as a boy, I think, in the very first Narnia chronicle, says this, "When Aslan said that you could never go back to Narnia, he meant the Narnia you were thinking of. But that was not the real Narnia that had a beginning and an end. It was in time," in the cave, as it were. "It was only a shadow or copy of the real Narnia, which has always been there and will always be there, outside time. Just as our own world, England, and all, is only a shadow or copy of something in Aslan's real world. You need not mourn over Narnia, Lucy. All of the old Narnia that matters, all the dear creatures have been drawn into the real Narnia through the door. And of course, it is different, as different as a real thing is from a shadow or as waking life is from a dream."
- 6.41** You can see the Christian Platonism. Plato, baptized by Lewis into the Christian tradition. The World of the Cave becomes earth, and the World of the Sun becomes Heaven. And it's the more real world. Heaven is more real than the earth down below. And the passage continues immediately. "His voice," Diggory Kirk's voice, "stirred everyone like a trumpet as he spoke these words. But when he added under his breath, "It's all in Plato. All in Plato. Bless me. What do they teach them at these schools? The older ones laughed."

- 6.42 Well, in this school, the Peterson Academy, it can at least be said that Plato has been taught, even if, as I sincerely hope, these lectures have been nothing more than a brief beginning of a lifelong journey from the cave out into the sunlight. A lifelong journey in allowing yourselves to be transformed in your minds and in your hearts by this titanic figure in the history of philosophy and by the glittering tradition that followed for millennia in his wake. Thanks for listening.
- 6.43 Gentleman?
- 6.44 You talk about how meaning is fixed, right? Fundamentally, I can say this in the sense of like: we interact, we have to have a mutual reference point, so that we can actually understand each other. To give an example: for example, a very old watch, it's worthless, meaningless, it means nothing. But if you add a significance to it, for example, "it's my father's deceased great-grandfather's watch." That in itself makes the fixed situation not really quite fixed. It appears to me that my sentimental attachment to this watch supersedes the used, general fixed meaning of a null watch. How would you rectify that?
- 6.45 So what you're describing there is a subjective evaluation of an object that you ascribe value to. And it's true value. It's a value that emerges in a way that makes sense out of a relationship with somebody you're close to, a relationship that exemplifies love, family, feeling, good things, objective things. So objective goods are exemplified by people, and every person is a subject. And just because a subject is evaluating an object in a way that ascribes greater value to than some other subject might, but in a way that is grounded in something that makes sense and would make sense to the person for whom the watch means nothing. They can say, "oh, I see." If you said, "How can you do that? That watch may not mean anything to you, but you don't understand what it means to me."
- 6.46 That scene in Pulp Fiction, think of the movie. "You don't understand," he says to his girlfriend, "I'm going right back. I don't care if I get killed." And she understands it. She gets it. She's disappointed, but she gets it because she can see that there is value there, even though she doesn't herself recognize it. But she understands that there is a subjective evaluation of value that is nevertheless, as it were, objective in that it matters. It makes sense. It's not just completely made up. It's emerged and recognized, and it's exemplifying a true objective value.
- 6.47 Compare you seeing a watch and saying that you've just bought, it means absolutely nothing to you. You say, "I'm going to imagine, and I declare that this is, in fact, a watch that was given to me long ago by my father. And you tell some kind of story, and you say that this is value, and you say, well, I'm the valuer, and the source of value is purely subjective. None of this Platonic stuff, thanks very much. And since I declare it to be valuable and I give it this story and just describe to it, boom, it has value." That would be false in a way that the previous circumstances were not. It would be inauthentic. Does that help?

- 6.48 Somebody who hasn't?
- 6.49 So you mentioned that Plato was suspicious of art because he thought it wasn't anchored in truth. But then you also said that he believed that ideas were more real than anything, more real than a rock. So is that because there's a difference between what's real and what's the truth? Like, art comes from a human, so that's their realness or their truthness make a universal truth? Or is there, like, a different reason for that?
- 6.50 Yeah. Thank you. One way of thinking about it might be to say that truth isn't something that you kind of discover, as I might have implied in the lectures, truth is something that arises in between a belief and the way the world is. And if that mirroring relationship is correct, then that's true. If there's conformity between the picture or the statement or the song or the poem, the belief and the way the world is, then we can say there's truth.
- 6.51 Plato's suspicious of the poets of his day because he thinks that they are completely indifferent to whether or not that relationship exhibits capital T Truth. He's suspicious of the sophists of his day because he thinks that they don't care about whether that relationship is aligned. They just want power. So sometimes it might be that they persuade people to speak the truth, sometimes they won't. But that suspicion gives way to, as it were, Plato as the poet. Plato as the poet who's allowed to be in the polis, in the city-state because he's entitled to develop his allegories and his parables and his pictures, because he can make sure that those pictures are properly aligned to the way that reality really is in a true way.
- 6.52 Plato's solution is to ban the poets, everyone else besides himself. However you've expressed that free speech is important. So, what is the solution to people who've fallen by, or are really interested in a false poet?
- 6.53 It's a great question. So Plato would not have been a fan of—one of the reasons he's not a fan of democracies is he's not a fan of unconstrained freedom. And you've put your finger on something that's a real tension in Plato. Because right from the beginning, the whole Dialogue Form presupposes that it's through free inquiry and the give and take of free inquiry that we get closer to truth. I think what Plato would say is that there can't be completely unconstrained freedom of speech. That freedom of speech needs parameters. Now, that's something that even the fiercest advocate of free speech should be comfortable with. Free speech is not an unqualified right. And there are certain things that the law rightly prohibits, and there are certain industries that the law should prohibit that claim merely to be expressing themselves using freedom of speech.
- 6.54 So I think in the Platonic case, in Plato's laws, and certainly in the Republic, there would be severely, probably limited parameters on what speech is possible. But there would be dialog, there would be dialectic, that's key for Plato. So that the Philosopher Rulers, as they're trained, are allowed to make mistakes, but the thought is that they've got

somebody who's attentive to their ignorance, who are willing to work through within those parameters, to work their way towards a true understanding of reality. But you're right that there's a kind of paradox here. And this is why Plato can infuriate the left as well as the right. He can be sort of a champion of free inquiry and philosophical reason. And he can also be a kind of fascistic, totalitarian dictator who wants to constrain those sorts of freedoms.

- 6.55** So I actually want to go back to the world of the thought. In our modern world, in universities, we're taught what to think as opposed to how to think. So how can we use Plato's wisdom in our modern world to break through from this devastating reality and get closer to the capital T, truth and capital M meaning?
- 6.56** Well, one of the things you can do is to do what you did on the first day, which is to download Plato's Apology and start reading some Plato. Why? Well, because I hope it's clear to you by now that Plato's not so much advancing philosophical ideas, though he is doing that, of course. But much more importantly, whether you agree with the ideas or not, he's advancing a method, a way of approaching problems. And even some of his signature positions, like the Theory of Forms, are positions that he exposes to devastating criticism and defeat elsewhere in his work. So he teaches us how to think, the Dialogue Forms that give and take, that truth as a collaborative exercise. Education as something that is a collaborative exercise in conversation, not simply being indoctrinated, but taught how to approach problems and shown where you've gone wrong, where your ignorance lies. Undertaken by a teacher who is humble, who considers himself wise because he considers himself to be ignorant and wise to his ignorance. Those are very powerful antidotes to the kind of crisis you're describing in higher education. And that, I hope, will be part of the value of the lectures you've been attending this week. Yes. You haven't asked a question yet.
- 6.57** When conversing with someone with a different truth, how can we use Mythos to disclose an objective Logos without falling prey to their own rhetoric to convey your own thoughts? Because you kind of need to use their own rhetoric, which by extension affirms their logic. Also, will this be on the final?
- 6.58** Great question, and I think the answer to it is to make sure that your philosophy final comes before your literature final. Because if you've done your finals that way round, then your understanding and your use and deployment of Mythos within your own life and with others will be anchored in a Logos. So make sure it's a logo-mythia, as opposed to mytho-logy, if you see what I mean. If you're starting with the literature and you're indulging your imagination unconstrained by any sort of deeper thought, or framed by some other conceptual framework, then the chances are when you then turn to some philosophy, you're just going to use that philosophy to force it into supporting the world that your imagination, run riot, has come up with.
- 6.59** Sir, since we find relative beauty, and what I mean by relative beauty is: a young version of someone who might be considered beautiful and then matter degrades. We

see relative goods, as in vegetables, but vegetables in excess don't become any good. And we see relative meaning as in helping others, or when we see the soldiers sacrificing themselves in war. And you said, "meaning is given," it cannot be deconstructed because we don't possess it, and if there's this relative meaning, there has to be an ultimate meaning. My question would be: what then is the ultimate meaning of man?

- 6.60** So, quick answer. Aristotle didn't like the idea that you could describe things as good or beautiful just because they instantiated the Form of the Good or the Beautiful. He didn't think that made any sense. What makes a knife good is very different from what makes a pen good. And so attributing goodness to a pen to a knife, and attributing goodness to a pen is a matter of understanding what a knife is for and what a pen is for. A pen doesn't need to be sharp, and a knife doesn't need ink. And you can say that you can establish in relative terms, but relative to an objective essence, relative to the objective essence of the pen and the knife. As for the final part of your question, the meaning of man. Well, the meaning of man is what it is to be human, for Plato is simply that, well, persons are souls, and a good person is a Well-Ordered Soul, that is, a person whose reason is in charge of spirit and appetite, and a bad person is a Disordered Soul. That's what Plato thought we were. And the meaning of person for Plato was that.
- 6.61** For Aristotle, it's slightly different. He unpacks that in Book 1 of Nicomachean Ethics. But whether there's some sort of ultimate meaning, ultimate destination for a person, Plato, there are indications in the Timaeus and in Book 10 of the Republic of there being a kind of afterlife that is very different from the sort of afterlives contemplated for Homer's heroes, which, as we see in Book 11 of the Odyssey, is pretty grim.
- 6.62** So I'm just struggling with a meaning here because we mentioned that we must inspect the world. And also one of the conclusions within the meaning was that heaven is more real than the world below it. So if we're caught in that loop of inspecting our world just to see that heaven is more real, then where, is the meaning in this one?
- 6.63** The meaning in this one is what's exemplified, what we catch a glimpse of, as it were, from the other world. It's a little bit like what Lewis is trying to explain in the Last Battle through Diggory Kirk, "Don't worry, Lucy, about losing things from the old Narnia. All that's good, all that you should care about in the old Narnia, in the Shadowlands, will be taken up and made perfect in the new Narnia, in the real Narnia."
- 6.64** And so the task of the philosopher or the seeker after truth is to work out where there are signals of transcendence, where the pathways up out of the cave truly lie, and that's always going to be an imperfect form of inquiry. But if you're sensitive to the risk, the thought is, and you're willing to scrutinize whether what you think is meaningfully true because it exemplifies something from the world above, if you're sensitive to that, Plato thinks you're going to have a much better chance of getting to truth.